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APPARATUS AND METHOD FOR VERIFICATION OF PRODUCT PACKAGE CONTENTS AND ACTIVATION OF CORRESPONDING DEVICES

Abstract

A system, method, and machine-readable medium are described for verification of devices in a product package. An optical code on a product package is scanned at a point-of-sale (POS) system and a digital code generated; an RF burst is generated to activate devices in the product package which transmit identification information. A device manifest is used indicating devices intended to be included in the product package. The identification information is compared with the set of devices indicated by the device manifest; and allowing a purchase of the product package to proceed if the identification information matches the set of devices; wherein if the identification information does not match the performing one or more secondary operations and/or providing instructions at the POS system to attempt to verify that the devices in the product package match the set of devices indicated by the device manifest.

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Background/Summary

BACKGROUND

Field of the Invention

[0001] This invention relates generally to the field of computer systems. More particularly, the invention relates to a system and method for verification of product package contents and activation of corresponding devices.

Description of the Related Art

[0002] The “Internet of Things” refers to the interconnection of uniquely-identifiable embedded devices within the Internet infrastructure. Ultimately, IoT is expected to result in new, wide-ranging types of applications in which virtually any type of physical thing may provide information about itself or its surroundings and/or may be controlled remotely via client devices over the Internet.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

[0003] A better understanding of the present invention can be obtained from the following detailed description in conjunction with the following drawings, in which:

[0004] FIGS. 1A-B illustrates different embodiments of an IoT system architecture;

[0005] FIG. 2 illustrates an IoT device in accordance with one embodiment of the invention;

[0006] FIG. 3 illustrates an IoT hub in accordance with one embodiment of the invention;

[0007] FIG. 4A-B illustrate embodiments of the invention for controlling and collecting data from IoT devices, and generating notifications;

[0008] FIG. 5 illustrates embodiments of the invention for collecting data from IoT devices and generating notifications from an IoT hub and/or IoT service;

[0009] FIG. 6 illustrates one embodiment of a system in which an intermediary mobile device collects data from a stationary IoT device and provides the data to an IoT hub;

[0010] FIG. 7 illustrates intermediary connection logic implemented in one embodiment of the invention;

[0011] FIG. 8 illustrates a method in accordance with one embodiment of the invention;

[0012] FIG. 9A illustrates an embodiment in which program code and data updates are provided to the IoT device;

[0013] FIG. 9B illustrates an embodiment of a method in which program code and data updates are provided to the IoT device;

[0014] FIG. 10 illustrates a high level view of one embodiment of a security architecture;

[0015] FIG. 11 illustrates one embodiment of an architecture in which a subscriber identity module (SIM) is used to store keys on IoT devices;

[0016] FIG. 12A illustrates one embodiment in which IoT devices are registered using barcodes or QR codes;

[0017] FIG. 12B illustrates one embodiment in which pairing is performed using barcodes or QR codes;

[0018] FIG. 13 illustrates one embodiment of a method for programming a SIM using an IoT hub;

[0019] FIG. 14 illustrates one embodiment of a method for registering an IoT device with an IoT hub and IoT service; and

[0020] FIG. 15 illustrates one embodiment of a method for encrypting data to be transmitted to an IoT device;

[0021] FIGS. 16A-B illustrate different embodiments of the invention for encrypting data between an IoT service and an IoT device;

[0022] FIG. **17** illustrates embodiments of the invention for performing a secure key exchange, generating a common secret, and using the secret to generate a key stream;

[0023] FIG. **18** illustrates a packet structure in accordance with one embodiment of the invention;

[0024] FIG. **19** illustrates techniques employed in one embodiment for writing and reading data to/from an IoT device without formally pairing with the IoT device;

[0025] FIG. **20** illustrates an exemplary set of command packets employed in one embodiment of the invention;

[0026] FIG. **21** illustrates an exemplary sequence of transactions using command packets;

[0027] FIG. **22** illustrates a method in accordance with one embodiment of the invention;

[0028] FIGS. **23A-C** illustrate a method for secure pairing in accordance with one embodiment of the invention;

[0029] FIG. **24** illustrates an example of non-electronic or unpowered (i.e., “passive”) device validation;

[0030] FIG. **25** illustrates multiple layers of signatures forming a chain of trust;

[0031] FIG. **26** illustrates an embodiment of a factory authenticator which has been authenticated to operate in a factory;

[0032] FIGS. **27A-B** illustrates a method in accordance with an embodiment of the invention;

[0033] FIG. **28** illustrates one embodiment for pairing a peripheral with a computer or mobile device;

[0034] FIG. **29** illustrates one embodiment of a sequence of transactions for pairing a peripheral with a computer or mobile device;

[0035] FIG. **30** illustrates one embodiment of the invention for pairing a headset with a multimedia system;

[0036] FIG. **31A** illustrates a method implemented at a POS system;

[0037] FIG. **31BA** illustrates a method implemented to setup/activate a device in accordance with some embodiments of the invention;

[0038] FIG. **32** illustrates one embodiment of a system for using a temporary session key to share video;

[0039] FIG. **33** illustrates another embodiment of a system for using a temporary session key to share video;

[0040] FIG. **34** illustrates one embodiment which uses Bluetooth communication;

[0041] FIG. **35** illustrates one embodiment which uses NFC and/or RFID communication; and

[0042] FIG. **36** illustrates a method in accordance with embodiments of the invention.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

[0043] In the following description, for the purposes of explanation, numerous specific details are set forth in order to provide a thorough understanding of the embodiments of the invention described below. It will be apparent, however, to one skilled in the art that the embodiments of the invention may be practiced without some of these specific details. In other instances, well-known structures and devices are shown in block diagram form to avoid obscuring the underlying principles of the embodiments of the invention.

[0044] One embodiment of the invention comprises an Internet of Things (IoT) platform which may be utilized by developers to design and build new IoT devices and applications. In particular, one embodiment includes a base hardware/software platform for IoT devices including a predefined networking protocol stack and an IoT hub through which the IoT devices are coupled to the Internet. In addition, one embodiment includes an IoT service through which the IoT hubs and connected IoT devices may be accessed and managed as described below. In addition, one embodiment of the IoT platform includes an IoT app or Web application (e.g., executed on a client device) to access and configured the IoT service, hub and connected devices. Existing online retailers and other Website operators may leverage the IoT platform described herein to readily provide unique IoT functionality to existing user bases.

[0045] FIG. 1A illustrates an overview of an architectural platform on which embodiments of the invention may be implemented. In particular, the illustrated embodiment includes a plurality of IoT devices **101-105** communicatively coupled over local communication channels **130** to a central IoT hub **110** which is itself communicatively coupled to an IoT service **120** over the Internet **220**. Each of the IoT devices **101-105** may initially be paired to the IoT hub **110** (e.g., using the pairing techniques described below) in order to enable each of the local communication channels **130**. In one embodiment, the IoT service **120** includes an end user database **122** for maintaining user account information and data collected from each user's IoT devices. For example, if the IoT devices include sensors (e.g., temperature sensors, accelerometers, heat sensors, motion detector, etc), the database **122** may be continually updated to store the data collected by the IoT devices **101-105**. The data stored in the database **122** may then be made accessible to the end user via the IoT app or browser installed on the user's device **135** (or via a desktop or other client computer system) and to web clients (e.g., such as websites **130** subscribing to the IoT service **120**

[0046] The IoT devices **101-105** may be equipped with various types of sensors to collect information about themselves and their surroundings and provide the collected information to the IoT service **120**, user devices **135** and/or external Websites **130** via the IoT hub **110**. Some of the IoT devices **101-105** may perform a specified function in response to control commands sent through the IoT hub **110**. Various specific examples of information collected by the IoT devices **101-105** and control commands are provided below. In one embodiment described below, the IoT device **101** is a user input device designed to record user selections and send the user selections to the IoT service **120** and/or Website.

[0047] In one embodiment, the IoT hub **110** includes a cellular radio to establish a connection to the Internet **220** via a cellular service **115** such as a 4G (e.g., Mobile WiMAX, LTE) or 5G cellular data service. Alternatively, or in addition, the IoT hub **110** may include a WiFi radio to establish a WiFi connection through a WiFi access point or router **116** which couples the IoT hub **110** to the Internet (e.g., via an Internet Service Provider providing Internet service to the end user). Of course, it should be noted that the underlying principles of the invention are not limited to any particular type of communication channel or protocol.

[0048] In one embodiment, the IoT devices **101-105** are ultra low-power devices capable of operating for extended periods of time on battery power (e.g., years). To conserve power, the local communication channels **130** may be implemented using a low-power wireless communication technology such as Bluetooth Low Energy (LE). In this embodiment, each of the IoT devices **101-105** and the IoT hub **110** are equipped with Bluetooth LE radios and protocol stacks.

[0049] As mentioned, in one embodiment, the IoT platform includes an IoT app or Web application executed on user devices **135** to allow users to access and configure the connected IoT devices **101-105**, IoT hub **110**, and/or IoT service **120**. In one embodiment, the app or web application may be designed by the operator of a Website **130** to provide IoT functionality to its user base. As illustrated, the Website may maintain a user database **131** containing account records related to each user.

[0050] FIG. 1B illustrates additional connection options for a plurality of IoT hubs **110-111**, **190**. In this embodiment a single user may have multiple hubs **110-111** installed onsite at a single user premises **180** (e.g., the user's home or business). This may be done, for example, to extend the wireless range needed to connect all of the IoT devices **101-105**. As indicated, if a user has multiple hubs **110**, **111** they may be connected via a local communication channel (e.g., Wifi, Ethernet, Power Line Networking, etc). In one embodiment, each of the hubs **110-111** may establish a direct connection to the IoT service **120** through a cellular **115** or WiFi **116** connection (not explicitly shown in FIG. 1B). Alternatively, or in addition, one of the IoT hubs such as IoT hub **110** may act as a "master" hub which provides connectivity and/or local services to all of the other IoT hubs on the user premises **180**, such as IoT hub **111** (as indicated by the dotted line connecting IoT hub **110** and IoT hub **111**). For example, the master IoT hub **110** may be the only IoT hub to establish a

direct connection to the IoT service **120**. In one embodiment, only the “master” IoT hub **110** is equipped with a cellular communication interface to establish the connection to the IoT service **120**. As such, all communication between the IoT service **120** and the other IoT hubs **111** will flow through the master IoT hub **110**. In this role, the master IoT hub **110** may be provided with additional program code to perform filtering operations on the data exchanged between the other IoT hubs **111** and IoT service **120** (e.g., servicing some data requests locally when possible).

[0051] Regardless of how the IoT hubs **110-111** are connected, in one embodiment, the IoT service **120** will logically associate the hubs with the user and combine all of the attached IoT devices **101-105** under a single comprehensive user interface, accessible via a user device with the installed app **135** (and/or a browser-based interface).

[0052] In this embodiment, the master IoT hub **110** and one or more slave IoT hubs **111** may connect over a local network which may be a WiFi network **116**, an Ethernet network, and/or a using power-line communications (PLC) networking (e.g., where all or portions of the network are run through the user's power lines). In addition, to the IoT hubs **110-111**, each of the IoT devices **101-105** may be interconnected with the IoT hubs **110-111** using any type of local network channel such as WiFi, Ethernet, PLC, or Bluetooth LE, to name a few.

[0053] FIG. **1B** also shows an IoT hub **190** installed at a second user premises **181**. A virtually unlimited number of such IoT hubs **190** may be installed and configured to collect data from IoT devices **191-192** at user premises around the world. In one embodiment, the two user premises **180-181** may be configured for the same user. For example, one user premises **180** may be the user's primary home and the other user premises **181** may be the user's vacation home. In such a case, the IoT service **120** will logically associate the IoT hubs **110-111**, **190** with the user and combine all of the attached IoT devices **101-105**, **191-192** under a single comprehensive user interface, accessible via a user device with the installed app **135** (and/or a browser-based interface).

[0054] As illustrated in FIG. **2**, an exemplary embodiment of an IoT device **101** includes a memory **210** for storing program code and data **201-203** and a low power microcontroller **200** for executing the program code and processing the data. The memory **210** may be a volatile memory such as dynamic random access memory (DRAM) or may be a non-volatile memory such as Flash memory. In one embodiment, a non-volatile memory may be used for persistent storage and a volatile memory may be used for execution of the program code and data at runtime. Moreover, the memory **210** may be integrated within the low power microcontroller **200** or may be coupled to the low power microcontroller **200** via a bus or communication fabric. The underlying principles of the invention are not limited to any particular implementation of the memory **210**.

[0055] As illustrated, the program code may include application program code **203** defining an application-specific set of functions to be performed by the IoT device **201** and library code **202** comprising a set of predefined building blocks which may be utilized by the application developer of the IoT device **101**. In one embodiment, the library code **202** comprises a set of basic functions required to implement an IoT device such as a communication protocol stack **201** for enabling communication between each IoT device **101** and the IoT hub **110**. As mentioned, in one embodiment, the communication protocol stack **201** comprises a Bluetooth LE protocol stack. In this embodiment, Bluetooth LE radio and antenna **207** may be integrated within the low power microcontroller **200**. However, the underlying principles of the invention are not limited to any particular communication protocol.

[0056] The particular embodiment shown in FIG. **2** also includes a plurality of input devices or sensors **210** to receive user input and provide the user input to the low power microcontroller, which processes the user input in accordance with the application code **203** and library code **202**. In one embodiment, each of the input devices include an LED **209** to provide feedback to the end user.

[0057] In addition, the illustrated embodiment includes a battery **208** for supplying power to the low power microcontroller. In one embodiment, a non-chargeable coin cell battery is used.

However, in an alternate embodiment, an integrated rechargeable battery may be used (e.g., rechargeable by connecting the IoT device to an AC power supply (not shown)).

[0058] A speaker **205** is also provided for generating audio. In one embodiment, the low power microcontroller **299** includes audio decoding logic for decoding a compressed audio stream (e.g., such as an MPEG-4/Advanced Audio Coding (AAC) stream) to generate audio on the speaker **205**. Alternatively, the low power microcontroller **200** and/or the application code/data **203** may include digitally sampled snippets of audio to provide verbal feedback to the end user as the user enters selections via the input devices **210**.

[0059] In one embodiment, one or more other/alternate I/O devices or sensors **250** may be included on the IoT device **101** based on the particular application for which the IoT device **101** is designed. For example, an environmental sensor may be included to measure temperature, pressure, humidity, etc. A security sensor and/or door lock opener may be included if the IoT device is used as a security device. Of course, these examples are provided merely for the purposes of illustration. The underlying principles of the invention are not limited to any particular type of IoT device. In fact, given the highly programmable nature of the low power microcontroller **200** equipped with the library code **202**, an application developer may readily develop new application code **203** and new I/O devices **250** to interface with the low power microcontroller for virtually any type of IoT application.

[0060] In one embodiment, the low power microcontroller **200** also includes a secure key store for storing encryption keys for encrypting communications and/or generating signatures. Alternatively, the keys may be secured in a subscriber identify module (SIM).

[0061] A wakeup receiver **207** is included in one embodiment to wake the IoT device from an ultra low power state in which it is consuming virtually no power. In one embodiment, the wakeup receiver **207** is configured to cause the IoT device **101** to exit this low power state in response to a wakeup signal received from a wakeup transmitter **307** configured on the IoT hub **110** as shown in FIG. 3. In particular, in one embodiment, the transmitter **307** and receiver **207** together form an electrical resonant transformer circuit such as a Tesla coil. In operation, energy is transmitted via radio frequency signals from the transmitter **307** to the receiver **207** when the hub **110** needs to wake the IoT device **101** from a very low power state. Because of the energy transfer, the IoT device **101** may be configured to consume virtually no power when it is in its low power state because it does not need to continually “listen” for a signal from the hub (as is the case with network protocols which allow devices to be awakened via a network signal). Rather, the microcontroller **200** of the IoT device **101** may be configured to wake up after being effectively powered down by using the energy electrically transmitted from the transmitter **307** to the receiver **207**.

[0062] As illustrated in FIG. 3, the IoT hub **110** also includes a memory **317** for storing program code and data **305** and hardware logic **301** such as a microcontroller for executing the program code and processing the data. A wide area network (WAN) interface **302** and antenna **310** couple the IoT hub **110** to the cellular service **115**. Alternatively, as mentioned above, the IoT hub **110** may also include a local network interface (not shown) such as a WiFi interface (and WiFi antenna) or Ethernet interface for establishing a local area network communication channel. In one embodiment, the hardware logic **301** also includes a secure key store for storing encryption keys for encrypting communications and generating/verifying signatures. Alternatively, the keys may be secured in a subscriber identify module (SIM).

[0063] A local communication interface **303** and antenna **311** establishes local communication channels with each of the IoT devices **101-105**. As mentioned above, in one embodiment, the local communication interface **303**/antenna **311** implements the Bluetooth LE standard. However, the underlying principles of the invention are not limited to any particular protocols for establishing the local communication channels with the IoT devices **101-105**. Although illustrated as separate units in FIG. 3, the WAN interface **302** and/or local communication interface **303** may be embedded

within the same chip as the hardware logic **301**.

[0064] In one embodiment, the program code and data includes a communication protocol stack **308** which may include separate stacks for communicating over the local communication interface **303** and the WAN interface **302**. In addition, device pairing program code and data **306** may be stored in the memory to allow the IoT hub to pair with new IoT devices. In one embodiment, each new IoT device **101-105** is assigned a unique code which is communicated to the IoT hub **110** during the pairing process. For example, the unique code may be embedded in a barcode on the IoT device and may be read by the barcode reader **106** or may be communicated over the local communication channel **130**. In an alternate embodiment, the unique ID code is embedded magnetically on the IoT device and the IoT hub has a magnetic sensor such as an radio frequency ID (RFID) or near field communication (NFC) sensor to detect the code when the IoT device **101** is moved within a few inches of the IoT hub **110**.

[0065] In one embodiment, once the unique ID has been communicated, the IoT hub **110** may verify the unique ID by querying a local database (not shown), performing a hash to verify that the code is acceptable, and/or communicating with the IoT service **120**, user device **135** and/or Website **130** to validate the ID code. Once validated, in one embodiment, the IoT hub **110** pairs the IoT device **101** and stores the pairing data in memory **317** (which, as mentioned, may include non-volatile memory). Once pairing is complete, the IoT hub **110** may connect with the IoT device **101** to perform the various IoT functions described herein.

[0066] In one embodiment, the organization running the IoT service **120** may provide the IoT hub **110** and a basic hardware/software platform to allow developers to easily design new IoT services. In particular, in addition to the IoT hub **110**, developers may be provided with a software development kit (SDK) to update the program code and data **305** executed within the hub **110**. In addition, for IoT devices **101**, the SDK may include an extensive set of library code **202** designed for the base IoT hardware (e.g., the low power microcontroller **200** and other components shown in FIG. 2) to facilitate the design of various different types of applications **101**. In one embodiment, the SDK includes a graphical design interface in which the developer needs only to specify input and outputs for the IoT device. All of the networking code, including the communication stack **201** that allows the IoT device **101** to connect to the hub **110** and the service **120**, is already in place for the developer. In addition, in one embodiment, the SDK also includes a library code base to facilitate the design of apps for mobile devices (e.g., iPhone and Android devices).

[0067] In one embodiment, the IoT hub **110** manages a continuous bi-directional stream of data between the IoT devices **101-105** and the IoT service **120**. In circumstances where updates to/from the IoT devices **101-105** are required in real time (e.g., where a user needs to view the current status of security devices or environmental readings), the IoT hub may maintain an open TCP socket to provide regular updates to the user device **135** and/or external Websites **130**. The specific networking protocol used to provide updates may be tweaked based on the needs of the underlying application. For example, in some cases, where may not make sense to have a continuous bi-directional stream, a simple request/response protocol may be used to gather information when needed.

[0068] In one embodiment, both the IoT hub **110** and the IoT devices **101-105** are automatically upgradeable over the network. In particular, when a new update is available for the IoT hub **110** it may automatically download and install the update from the IoT service **120**. It may first copy the updated code into a local memory, run and verify the update before swapping out the older program code. Similarly, when updates are available for each of the IoT devices **101-105**, they may initially be downloaded by the IoT hub **110** and pushed out to each of the IoT devices **101-105**. Each IoT device **101-105** may then apply the update in a similar manner as described above for the IoT hub and report back the results of the update to the IoT hub **110**. If the update is successful, then the IoT hub **110** may delete the update from its memory and record the latest version of code installed on each IoT device (e.g., so that it may continue to check for new updates for each IoT device).

[0069] In one embodiment, the IoT hub **110** is powered via A/C power. In particular, the IoT hub **110** may include a power unit **390** with a transformer for transforming A/C voltage supplied via an A/C power cord to a lower DC voltage.

[0070] FIG. **4A** illustrates one embodiment of the invention for performing universal remote control operations using the IoT system. In particular, in this embodiment, a set of IoT devices **101-103** are equipped with infrared (IR) and/or radio frequency (RF) blasters **401-403**, respectively, for transmitting remote control codes to control various different types of electronics equipment including air conditioners/heaters **430**, lighting systems **431**, and audiovisual equipment **432** (to name just a few). In the embodiment shown in FIG. **4A**, the IoT devices **101-103** are also equipped with sensors **404-406**, respectively, for detecting the operation of the devices which they control, as described below.

[0071] For example, sensor **404** in IoT device **101** may be a temperature and/or humidity sensor for sensing the current temperature/humidity and responsively controlling the air conditioner/heater **430** based on a current desired temperature. In this embodiment, the air conditioner/heater **430** is one which is designed to be controlled via a remote control device (typically a remote control which itself has a temperature sensor embedded therein). In one embodiment, the user provides the desired temperature to the IoT hub **110** via an app or browser installed on a user device **135**.

Control logic **412** executed on the IoT hub **110** receives the current temperature/humidity data from the sensor **404** and responsively transmits commands to the IoT device **101** to control the IR/RF blaster **401** in accordance with the desired temperature/humidity. For example, if the temperature is below the desired temperature, then the control logic **412** may transmit a command to the air conditioner/heater via the IR/RF blaster **401** to increase the temperature (e.g., either by turning off the air conditioner or turning on the heater). The command may include the necessary remote control code stored in a database **413** on the IoT hub **110**. Alternatively, or in addition, the IoT service **421** may implement control logic **421** to control the electronics equipment **430-432** based on specified user preferences and stored control codes **422**.

[0072] IoT device **102** in the illustrated example is used to control lighting **431**. In particular, sensor **405** in IoT device **102** may be a photosensor or photodetector configured to detect the current brightness of the light being produced by a light fixture **431** (or other lighting apparatus). The user may specify a desired lighting level (including an indication of ON or OFF) to the IoT hub **110** via the user device **135**. In response, the control logic **412** will transmit commands to the IR/RF blaster **402** to control the current brightness level of the lights **431** (e.g., increasing the lighting if the current brightness is too low or decreasing the lighting if the current brightness is too high; or simply turning the lights ON or OFF).

[0073] IoT device **103** in the illustrated example is configured to control audiovisual equipment **432** (e.g., a television, A/V receiver, cable/satellite receiver, AppleTV™, etc). Sensor **406** in IoT device **103** may be an audio sensor (e.g., a microphone and associated logic) for detecting a current ambient volume level and/or a photosensor to detect whether a television is on or off based on the light generated by the television (e.g., by measuring the light within a specified spectrum). Alternatively, sensor **406** may include a temperature sensor connected to the audiovisual equipment to detect whether the audio equipment is on or off based on the detected temperature. Once again, in response to user input via the user device **135**, the control logic **412** may transmit commands to the audiovisual equipment via the IR blaster **403** of the IoT device **103**.

[0074] It should be noted that the foregoing are merely illustrative examples of one embodiment of the invention. The underlying principles of the invention are not limited to any particular type of sensors or equipment to be controlled by IoT devices.

[0075] In an embodiment in which the IoT devices **101-103** are coupled to the IoT hub **110** via a Bluetooth LE connection, the sensor data and commands are sent over the Bluetooth LE channel. However, the underlying principles of the invention are not limited to Bluetooth LE or any other communication standard.

[0076] In one embodiment, the control codes required to control each of the pieces of electronics equipment are stored in a database **413** on the IoT hub **110** and/or a database **422** on the IoT service **120**. As illustrated in FIG. 4B, the control codes may be provided to the IoT hub **110** from a master database of control codes **422** for different pieces of equipment maintained on the IoT service **120**. The end user may specify the types of electronic (or other) equipment to be controlled via the app or browser executed on the user device **135** and, in response, a remote control code learning module **491** on the IoT hub may retrieve the required IR/RF codes from the remote control code database **492** on the IoT service **120** (e.g., identifying each piece of electronic equipment with a unique ID).

[0077] In addition, in one embodiment, the IoT hub **110** is equipped with an IR/RF interface **490** to allow the remote control code learning module **491** to “learn” new remote control codes directly from the original remote control **495** provided with the electronic equipment. For example, if control codes for the original remote control provided with the air conditioner **430** is not included in the remote control database, the user may interact with the IoT hub **110** via the app/browser on the user device **135** to teach the IoT hub **110** the various control codes generated by the original remote control (e.g., increase temperature, decrease temperature, etc). Once the remote control codes are learned they may be stored in the control code database **413** on the IoT hub **110** and/or sent back to the IoT service **120** to be included in the central remote control code database **492** (and subsequently used by other users with the same air conditioner unit **430**).

[0078] In one embodiment, each of the IoT devices **101-103** have an extremely small form factor and may be affixed on or near their respective electronics equipment **430-432** using double-sided tape, a small nail, a magnetic attachment, etc. For control of a piece of equipment such as the air conditioner **430**, it would be desirable to place the IoT device **101** sufficiently far away so that the sensor **404** can accurately measure the ambient temperature in the home (e.g., placing the IoT device directly on the air conditioner would result in a temperature measurement which would be too low when the air conditioner was running or too high when the heater was running). In contrast, the IoT device **102** used for controlling lighting may be placed on or near the lighting fixture **431** for the sensor **405** to detect the current lighting level.

[0079] In addition to providing general control functions as described, one embodiment of the IoT hub **110** and/or IoT service **120** transmits notifications to the end user related to the current status of each piece of electronics equipment. The notifications, which may be text messages and/or app-specific notifications, may then be displayed on the display of the user's mobile device **135**. For example, if the user's air conditioner has been on for an extended period of time but the temperature has not changed, the IoT hub **110** and/or IoT service **120** may send the user a notification that the air conditioner is not functioning properly. If the user is not home (which may be detected via motion sensors or based on the user's current detected location), and the sensors **406** indicate that audiovisual equipment **430** is on or sensors **405** indicate that the lights are on, then a notification may be sent to the user, asking if the user would like to turn off the audiovisual equipment **432** and/or lights **431**. The same type of notification may be sent for any equipment type.

[0080] Once the user receives a notification, he/she may remotely control the electronics equipment **430-432** via the app or browser on the user device **135**. In one embodiment, the user device **135** is a touchscreen device and the app or browser displays an image of a remote control with user-selectable buttons for controlling the equipment **430-432**. Upon receiving a notification, the user may open the graphical remote control and turn off or adjust the various different pieces of equipment. If connected via the IoT service **120**, the user's selections may be forwarded from the IoT service **120** to the IoT hub **110** which will then control the equipment via the control logic **412**. Alternatively, the user input may be sent directly to the IoT hub **110** from the user device **135**.

[0081] In one embodiment, the user may program the control logic **412** on the IoT hub **110** to perform various automatic control functions with respect to the electronics equipment **430-432**. In

addition to maintaining a desired temperature, brightness level, and volume level as described above, the control logic **412** may automatically turn off the electronics equipment if certain conditions are detected. For example, if the control logic **412** detects that the user is not home and that the air conditioner is not functioning, it may automatically turn off the air conditioner. Similarly, if the user is not home, and the sensors **406** indicate that audiovisual equipment **430** is on or sensors **405** indicate that the lights are on, then the control logic **412** may automatically transmit commands via the IR/RF blasters **403** and **402**, to turn off the audiovisual equipment and lights, respectively.

[0082] FIG. 5 illustrates additional embodiments of IoT devices **104-105** equipped with sensors **503-504** for monitoring electronic equipment **530-531**. In particular, the IoT device **104** of this embodiment includes a temperature sensor **503** which may be placed on or near a stove **530** to detect when the stove has been left on. In one embodiment, the IoT device **104** transmits the current temperature measured by the temperature sensor **503** to the IoT hub **110** and/or the IoT service **120**. If the stove is detected to be on for more than a threshold time period (e.g., based on the measured temperature), then control logic **512** may transmit a notification to the end user's device **135** informing the user that the stove **530** is on. In addition, in one embodiment, the IoT device **104** may include a control module **501** to turn off the stove, either in response to receiving an instruction from the user or automatically (if the control logic **512** is programmed to do so by the user). In one embodiment, the control logic **501** comprises a switch to cut off electricity or gas to the stove **530**. However, in other embodiments, the control logic **501** may be integrated within the stove itself.

[0083] FIG. 5 also illustrates an IoT device **105** with a motion sensor **504** for detecting the motion of certain types of electronics equipment such as a washer and/or dryer. Another sensor that may be used is an audio sensor (e.g., microphone and logic) for detecting an ambient volume level. As with the other embodiments described above, this embodiment may transmit notifications to the end user if certain specified conditions are met (e.g., if motion is detected for an extended period of time, indicating that the washer/dryer are not turning off). Although not shown in FIG. 5, IoT device **105** may also be equipped with a control module to turn off the washer/dryer **531** (e.g., by switching off electric/gas), automatically, and/or in response to user input.

[0084] In one embodiment, a first IoT device with control logic and a switch may be configured to turn off all power in the user's home and a second IoT device with control logic and a switch may be configured to turn off all gas in the user's home. IoT devices with sensors may then be positioned on or near electronic or gas-powered equipment in the user's home. If the user is notified that a particular piece of equipment has been left on (e.g., the stove **530**), the user may then send a command to turn off all electricity or gas in the home to prevent damage. Alternatively, the control logic **512** in the IoT hub **110** and/or the IoT service **120** may be configured to automatically turn off electricity or gas in such situations.

[0085] In one embodiment, the IoT hub **110** and IoT service **120** communicate at periodic intervals. If the IoT service **120** detects that the connection to the IoT hub **110** has been lost (e.g., by failing to receive a request or response from the IoT hub for a specified duration), it will communicate this information to the end user's device **135** (e.g., by sending a text message or app-specific notification).

Apparatus and Method for Communicating Data Through an Intermediary Device

[0086] As mentioned above, because the wireless technologies used to interconnect IoT devices such as Bluetooth LE are generally short range technologies, if the hub for an IoT implementation is outside the range of an IoT device, the IoT device will not be able to transmit data to the IoT hub (and vice versa).

[0087] To address this deficiency, one embodiment of the invention provides a mechanism for an IoT device which is outside of the wireless range of the IoT hub to periodically connect with one or more mobile devices when the mobile devices are within range. Once connected, the IoT device

can transmit any data which needs to be provided to the IoT hub to the mobile device which then forwards the data to the IoT hub.

[0088] As illustrated in FIG. 6 one embodiment includes an IoT hub **110**, an IoT device **601** which is out of range of the IoT hub **110** and a mobile device **611**. The out of range IoT device **601** may include any form of IoT device capable of collecting and communicating data. For example, the IoT device **601** may comprise a data collection device configured within a refrigerator to monitor the food items available in the refrigerator, the users who consume the food items, and the current temperature. Of course, the underlying principles of the invention are not limited to any particular type of IoT device. The techniques described herein may be implemented using any type of IoT device including those used to collect and transmit data for smart meters, stoves, washers, dryers, lighting systems, HVAC systems, and audiovisual equipment, to name just a few.

[0089] Moreover, the mobile device In operation, the IoT device **611** illustrated in FIG. 6 may be any form of mobile device capable of communicating and storing data. For example, in one embodiment, the mobile device **611** is a smartphone with an app installed thereon to facilitate the techniques described herein. In another embodiment, the mobile device **611** comprises a wearable device such as a communication token affixed to a neckless or bracelet, a smartwatch or a fitness device. The wearable token may be particularly useful for elderly users or other users who do not own a smartphone device.

[0090] In operation, the out of range IoT device **601** may periodically or continually check for connectivity with a mobile device **611**. Upon establishing a connection (e.g., as the result of the user moving within the vicinity of the refrigerator) any collected data **605** on the IoT device **601** is automatically transmitted to a temporary data repository **615** on the mobile device **611**. In one embodiment, the IoT device **601** and mobile device **611** establish a local wireless communication channel using a low power wireless standard such as BTLE. In such a case, the mobile device **611** may initially be paired with the IoT device **601** using known pairing techniques.

[0091] Once the data has been transferred to the temporary data repository, the mobile device **611** will transmit the data once communication is established with the IoT hub **110** (e.g., when the user walks within the range of the IoT hub **110**). The IoT hub may then store the data in a central data repository **413** and/or send the data over the Internet to one or more services and/or other user devices. In one embodiment, the mobile device **611** may use a different type of communication channel to provide the data to the IoT hub **110** (potentially a higher power communication channel such as WiFi).

[0092] The out of range IoT device **601**, the mobile device **611**, and the IoT hub may all be configured with program code and/or logic to implement the techniques described herein. As illustrated in FIG. 7, for example, the IoT device **601** may be configured with intermediary connection logic and/or application, the mobile device **611** may be configured with an intermediary connection logic/application, and the IoT hub **110** may be configured with an intermediary connection logic/application **721** to perform the operations described herein. The intermediary connection logic/application on each device may be implemented in hardware, software, or any combination thereof. In one embodiment, the intermediary connection logic/application **701** of the IoT device **601** searches and establishes a connection with the intermediary connection logic/application **711** on the mobile device (which may be implemented as a device app) to transfer the data to the temporary data repository **615**. The intermediary connection logic/application **701** on the mobile device **611** then forwards the data to the intermediary connection logic/application on the IoT hub, which stores the data in the central data repository **413**.

[0093] As illustrated in FIG. 7, the intermediary connection logic/applications **701**, **711**, **721**, on each device may be configured based on the application at hand. For example, for a refrigerator, the connection logic/application **701** may only need to transmit a few packets on a periodic basis. For other applications (e.g., temperature sensors), the connection logic/application **701** may need to transmit more frequent updates.

[0094] Rather than a mobile device **611**, in one embodiment, the IoT device **601** may be configured to establish a wireless connection with one or more intermediary IoT devices, which are located within range of the IoT hub **110**. In this embodiment, any IoT devices **601** out of range of the IoT hub may be linked to the hub by forming a “chain” using other IoT devices.

[0095] In addition, while only a single mobile device **611** is illustrated in FIGS. **6-7** for simplicity, in one embodiment, multiple such mobile devices of different users may be configured to communicate with the IoT device **601**. Moreover, the same techniques may be implemented for multiple other IoT devices, thereby forming an intermediary device data collection system across the entire home.

[0096] Moreover, in one embodiment, the techniques described herein may be used to collect various different types of pertinent data. For example, in one embodiment, each time the mobile device **611** connects with the IoT device **601**, the identity of the user may be included with the collected data **605**. In this manner, the IoT system may be used to track the behavior of different users within the home. For example, if used within a refrigerator, the collected data **605** may then include the identify of each user who passes by fridge, each user who opens the fridge, and the specific food items consumed by each user. Different types of data may be collected from other types of IoT devices. Using this data the system is able to determine, for example, which user washes clothes, which user watches TV on a given day, the times at which each user goes to sleep and wakes up, etc. All of this crowd-sourced data may then be compiled within the data repository **413** of the IoT hub and/or forwarded to an external service or user.

[0097] Another beneficial application of the techniques described herein is for monitoring elderly users who may need assistance. For this application, the mobile device **611** may be a very small token worn by the elderly user to collect the information in different rooms of the user's home. Each time the user opens the refrigerator, for example, this data will be included with the collected data **605** and transferred to the IoT hub **110** via the token. The IoT hub may then provide the data to one or more external users (e.g., the children or other individuals who care for the elderly user). If data has not been collected for a specified period of time (e.g., 12 hours), then this means that the elderly user has not been moving around the home and/or has not been opening the refrigerator. The IoT hub **110** or an external service connected to the IoT hub may then transmit an alert notification to these other individuals, informing them that they should check on the elderly user. In addition, the collected data **605** may include other pertinent information such as the food being consumed by the user and whether a trip to the grocery store is needed, whether and how frequently the elderly user is watching TV, the frequency with which the elderly user washes clothes, etc.

[0098] In another implementation, the if there is a problem with an electronic device such as a washer, refrigerator, HVAC system, etc, the collected data may include an indication of a part that needs to be replaced. In such a case, a notification may be sent to a technician with a request to fix the problem. The technician may then arrive at the home with the needed replacement part.

[0099] A method in accordance with one embodiment of the invention is illustrated in FIG. **8**. The method may be implemented within the context of the architectures described above, but is not limited to any particular architecture.

[0100] At **801**, an IoT device which is out of range of the IoT hub periodically collects data (e.g., opening of the refrigerator door, food items used, etc). At **802** the IoT device periodically or continually checks for connectivity with a mobile device (e.g., using standard local wireless techniques for establishing a connection such as those specified by the BTLE standard). If the connection to the mobile device is established, determined at **802**, then at **803**, the collected data is transferred to the mobile device at **803**. At **804**, the mobile device transfers the data to the IoT hub, an external service and/or a user. As mentioned, the mobile device may transmit the data immediately if it is already connected (e.g., via a WiFi link).

[0101] In addition to collecting data from IoT devices, in one embodiment, the techniques described herein may be used to update or otherwise provide data to IoT devices. One example is

shown in FIG. 9A, which shows an IoT hub **110** with program code updates **901** that need to be installed on an IoT device **601** (or a group of such IoT devices). The program code updates may include system updates, patches, configuration data and any other data needed for the IoT device to operate as desired by the user. In one embodiment, the user may specify configuration options for the IoT device **601** via a mobile device or computer which are then stored on the IoT hub **110** and provided to the IoT device using the techniques described herein. Specifically, in one embodiment, the intermediary connection logic/application **721** on the IoT hub **110** communicates with the intermediary connection logic/application **711** on the mobile device **611** to store the program code updates within a temporary storage **615**. When the mobile device **611** enters the range of the IoT device **601**, the intermediary connection logic/application **711** on the mobile device **611** connects with the intermediary/connection logic/application **701** on the IoT device **601** to provide the program code updates to the device. In one embodiment, the IoT device **601** may then enter into an automated update process to install the new program code updates and/or data.

[0102] A method for updating an IoT device is shown in FIG. 9B. The method may be implemented within the context of the system architectures described above, but is not limited to any particular system architectures.

[0103] At **900** new program code or data updates are made available on the IoT hub and/or an external service (e.g., coupled to the mobile device over the Internet). At **901**, the mobile device receives and stores the program code or data updates on behalf of the IoT device. The IoT device and/or mobile device periodically check to determine whether a connection has been established at **902**. If a connection is established, determined at **903**, then at **904** the updates are transferred to the IoT device and installed.

Embodiments for Improved Security

[0104] In one embodiment, the low power microcontroller **200** of each IoT device **101** and the low power logic/microcontroller **301** of the IoT hub **110** include a secure key store for storing encryption keys used by the embodiments described below (see, e.g., FIGS. **10-15** and associated text). Alternatively, the keys may be secured in a subscriber identify module (SIM) as discussed below.

[0105] FIG. **10** illustrates a high level architecture which uses public key infrastructure (PKI) techniques and/or symmetric key exchange/encryption techniques to encrypt communications between the IoT Service **120**, the IoT hub **110** and the IoT devices **101-102**.

[0106] Embodiments which use public/private key pairs will first be described, followed by embodiments which use symmetric key exchange/encryption techniques. In particular, in an embodiment which uses PKI, a unique public/private key pair is associated with each IoT device **101-102**, each IoT hub **110** and the IoT service **120**. In one embodiment, when a new IoT hub **110** is set up, its public key is provided to the IoT service **120** and when a new IoT device **101** is set up, its public key is provided to both the IoT hub **110** and the IoT service **120**. Various techniques for securely exchanging the public keys between devices are described below. In one embodiment, all public keys are signed by a master key known to all of the receiving devices (i.e., a form of certificate) so that any receiving device can verify the validity of the public keys by validating the signatures. Thus, these certificates would be exchanged rather than merely exchanging the raw public keys.

[0107] As illustrated, in one embodiment, each IoT device **101, 102** includes a secure key storage **1001, 1003**, respectively, for securely storing each device's private key. Security subsystem **1002, 1304** then utilizes the securely stored private keys to perform the encryption/decryption operations described herein. Similarly, the IoT hub **110** includes a secure storage **1011** for storing the IoT hub private key and the public keys of the IoT devices **101-102** and the IoT service **120**; as well as security subsystem **1012** for using the keys to perform encryption/decryption operations. Finally, the IoT service **120** may include a secure storage **1021** for securely storing its own private key, the public keys of various IoT devices and IoT hubs, and a security subsystem **1013** for using the keys

to encrypt/decrypt communication with IoT hubs and devices. In one embodiment, when the IoT hub **110** receives a public key certificate from an IoT device it can verify it (e.g., by validating the signature using the master key as described above), and then extract the public key from within it and store that public key in its secure key store **1011**.

[0108] By way of example, in one embodiment, when the IoT service **120** needs to transmit a command or data to an IoT device **101** (e.g., a command to unlock a door, a request to read a sensor, data to be processed/displayed by the IoT device, etc) the security subsystem **1013** encrypts the data/command using the public key of the IoT device **101** to generate an encrypted IoT device packet. In one embodiment, it then encrypts the IoT device packet using the public key of the IoT hub **110** to generate an IoT hub packet and transmits the IoT hub packet to the IoT hub **110**. In one embodiment, the service **120** signs the encrypted message with its private key or the master key mentioned above so that the device **101** can verify it is receiving an unaltered message from a trusted source. The device **101** may then validate the signature using the public key corresponding to the private key and/or the master key. As mentioned above, symmetric key exchange/encryption techniques may be used instead of public/private key encryption. In these embodiments, rather than privately storing one key and providing a corresponding public key to other devices, the devices may each be provided with a copy of the same symmetric key to be used for encryption and to validate signatures. One example of a symmetric key algorithm is the Advanced Encryption Standard (AES), although the underlying principles of the invention are not limited to any type of specific symmetric keys.

[0109] Using a symmetric key implementation, each device **101** enters into a secure key exchange protocol to exchange a symmetric key with the IoT hub **110**. A secure key provisioning protocol such as the Dynamic Symmetric Key Provisioning Protocol (DSKPP) may be used to exchange the keys over a secure communication channel (see, e.g., Request for Comments (RFC) 6063). However, the underlying principles of the invention are not limited to any particular key provisioning protocol.

[0110] Once the symmetric keys have been exchanged, they may be used by each device **101** and the IoT hub **110** to encrypt communications. Similarly, the IoT hub **110** and IoT service **120** may perform a secure symmetric key exchange and then use the exchanged symmetric keys to encrypt communications. In one embodiment a new symmetric key is exchanged periodically between the devices **101** and the hub **110** and between the hub **110** and the IoT service **120**. In one embodiment, a new symmetric key is exchanged with each new communication session between the devices **101**, the hub **110**, and the service **120** (e.g., a new key is generated and securely exchanged for each communication session). In one embodiment, if the security module **1012** in the IoT hub is trusted, the service **120** could negotiate a session key with the hub security module **1312** and then the security module **1012** would negotiate a session key with each device **120**. Messages from the service **120** would then be decrypted and verified in the hub security module **1012** before being re-encrypted for transmission to the device **101**.

[0111] In one embodiment, to prevent a compromise on the hub security module **1012** a one-time (permanent) installation key may be negotiated between the device **101** and service **120** at installation time. When sending a message to a device **101** the service **120** could first encrypt/MAC with this device installation key, then encrypt/MAC that with the hub's session key. The hub **110** would then verify and extract the encrypted device blob and send that to the device.

[0112] In one embodiment of the invention, a counter mechanism is implemented to prevent replay attacks. For example, each successive communication from the device **101** to the hub **110** (or vice versa) may be assigned a continually increasing counter value. Both the hub **110** and device **101** will track this value and verify that the value is correct in each successive communication between the devices. The same techniques may be implemented between the hub **110** and the service **120**. Using a counter in this manner would make it more difficult to spoof the communication between each of the devices (because the counter value would be incorrect). However, even without this a

shared installation key between the service and device would prevent network (hub) wide attacks to all devices.

[0113] In one embodiment, when using public/private key encryption, the IoT hub **110** uses its private key to decrypt the IoT hub packet and generate the encrypted IoT device packet, which it transmits to the associated IoT device **101**. The IoT device **101** then uses its private key to decrypt the IoT device packet to generate the command/data originated from the IoT service **120**. It may then process the data and/or execute the command. Using symmetric encryption, each device would encrypt and decrypt with the shared symmetric key. If either case, each transmitting device may also sign the message with its private key so that the receiving device can verify its authenticity.

[0114] A different set of keys may be used to encrypt communication from the IoT device **101** to the IoT hub **110** and to the IoT service **120**. For example, using a public/private key arrangement, in one embodiment, the security subsystem **1002** on the IoT device **101** uses the public key of the IoT hub **110** to encrypt data packets sent to the IoT hub **110**. The security subsystem **1012** on the IoT hub **110** may then decrypt the data packets using the IoT hub's private key. Similarly, the security subsystem **1002** on the IoT device **101** and/or the security subsystem **1012** on the IoT hub **110** may encrypt data packets sent to the IoT service **120** using the public key of the IoT service **120** (which may then be decrypted by the security subsystem **1013** on the IoT service **120** using the service's private key). Using symmetric keys, the device **101** and hub **110** may share a symmetric key while the hub and service **120** may share a different symmetric key.

[0115] While certain specific details are set forth above in the description above, it should be noted that the underlying principles of the invention may be implemented using various different encryption techniques. For example, while some embodiments discussed above use asymmetric public/private key pairs, an alternate embodiment may use symmetric keys securely exchanged between the various IoT devices **101-102**, IoT hubs **110**, and the IoT service **120**. Moreover, in some embodiments, the data/command itself is not encrypted, but a key is used to generate a signature over the data/command (or other data structure). The recipient may then use its key to validate the signature.

[0116] As illustrated in FIG. **11**, in one embodiment, the secure key storage on each IoT device **101** is implemented using a programmable subscriber identity module (SIM) **1101**. In this embodiment, the IoT device **101** may initially be provided to the end user with an un-programmed SIM card **1101** seated within a SIM interface **1100** on the IoT device **101**. In order to program the SIM with a set of one or more encryption keys, the user takes the programmable SIM card **1101** out of the SIM interface **500** and inserts it into a SIM programming interface **1102** on the IoT hub **110**.

Programming logic **1125** on the IoT hub then securely programs the SIM card **1101** to register/pair the IoT device **101** with the IoT hub **110** and IoT service **120**. In one embodiment, a public/private key pair may be randomly generated by the programming logic **1125** and the public key of the pair may then be stored in the IoT hub's secure storage device **411** while the private key may be stored within the programmable SIM **1101**. In addition, the programming logic **525** may store the public keys of the IoT hub **110**, the IoT service **120**, and/or any other IoT devices **101** on the SIM card **1401** (to be used by the security subsystem **1302** on the IoT device **101** to encrypt outgoing data). Once the SIM **1101** is programmed, the new IoT device **101** may be provisioned with the IoT Service **120** using the SIM as a secure identifier (e.g., using existing techniques for registering a device using a SIM). Following provisioning, both the IoT hub **110** and the IoT service **120** will securely store a copy of the IoT device's public key to be used when encrypting communication with the IoT device **101**.

[0117] The techniques described above with respect to FIG. **11** provide enormous flexibility when providing new IoT devices to end users. Rather than requiring a user to directly register each SIM with a particular service provider upon sale/purchase (as is currently done), the SIM may be programmed directly by the end user via the IoT hub **110** and the results of the programming may

be securely communicated to the IoT service **120**. Consequently, new IoT devices **101** may be sold to end users from online or local retailers and later securely provisioned with the IoT service **120**. [0118] While the registration and encryption techniques are described above within the specific context of a SIM (Subscriber Identity Module), the underlying principles of the invention are not limited to a “SIM” device. Rather, the underlying principles of the invention may be implemented using any type of device having secure storage for storing a set of encryption keys. Moreover, while the embodiments above include a removable SIM device, in one embodiment, the SIM device is not removable but the IoT device itself may be inserted within the programming interface **1102** of the IoT hub **110**.

[0119] In one embodiment, rather than requiring the user to program the SIM (or other device), the SIM is pre-programmed into the IoT device **101**, prior to distribution to the end user. In this embodiment, when the user sets up the IoT device **101**, various techniques described herein may be used to securely exchange encryption keys between the IoT hub **110**/IoT service **120** and the new IoT device **101**.

[0120] For example, as illustrated in FIG. **12A** each IoT device **101** or SIM **401** may be packaged with a barcode or QR code **1501** uniquely identifying the IoT device **101** and/or SIM **1001**. In one embodiment, the barcode or QR code **1201** comprises an encoded representation of the public key for the IoT device **101** or SIM **1001**. Alternatively, the barcode or QR code **1201** may be used by the IoT hub **110** and/or IoT service **120** to identify or generate the public key (e.g., used as a pointer to the public key which is already stored in secure storage). The barcode or QR code **601** may be printed on a separate card (as shown in FIG. **12A**) or may be printed directly on the IoT device itself. Regardless of where the barcode is printed, in one embodiment, the IoT hub **110** is equipped with a barcode reader **206** for reading the barcode and providing the resulting data to the security subsystem **1012** on the IoT hub **110** and/or the security subsystem **1013** on the IoT service **120**. The security subsystem **1012** on the IoT hub **110** may then store the public key for the IoT device within its secure key storage **1011** and the security subsystem **1013** on the IoT service **120** may store the public key within its secure storage **1021** (to be used for subsequent encrypted communication).

[0121] In one embodiment, the data contained in the barcode or QR code **1201** may also be captured via a user device **135** (e.g., such as an iPhone or Android device) with an installed IoT app or browser-based applet designed by the IoT service provider. Once captured, the barcode data may be securely communicated to the IoT service **120** over a secure connection (e.g., such as a secure sockets layer (SSL) connection). The barcode data may also be provided from the client device **135** to the IoT hub **110** over a secure local connection (e.g., over a local WiFi or Bluetooth LE connection).

[0122] The security subsystem **1002** on the IoT device **101** and the security subsystem **1012** on the IoT hub **110** may be implemented using hardware, software, firmware or any combination thereof. For example, in one embodiment, the security subsystem **1002**, **1012** is implemented within the chips used for establishing the local communication channel **130** between the IoT device **101** and the IoT hub **110** (e.g., the Bluetooth LE chip if the local channel **130** is Bluetooth LE). Regardless of the specific location of the security subsystem **1002**, **1012**, in one embodiment, the security subsystem **1002**, **1012** is designed to establish a secure execution environment for executing certain types of program code. This may be implemented, for example, by using TrustZone technology (available on some ARM processors) and/or Trusted Execution Technology (designed by Intel). Of course, the underlying principles of the invention are not limited to any particular type of secure execution technology.

[0123] In one embodiment, the barcode or QR code **1501** may be used to pair each IoT device **101** with the IoT hub **110**. For example, rather than using the standard wireless pairing process currently used to pair Bluetooth LE devices, a pairing code embedded within the barcode or QR code **1501** may be provided to the IoT hub **110** to pair the IoT hub with the corresponding IoT

device.

[0124] FIG. 12B illustrates one embodiment in which the barcode reader **206** on the IoT hub **110** captures the barcode/QR code **1201** associated with the IoT device **101**. As mentioned, the barcode/QR code **1201** may be printed directly on the IoT device **101** or may be printed on a separate card provided with the IoT device **101**. In either case, the barcode reader **206** reads the pairing code from the barcode/QR code **1201** and provides the pairing code to the local communication module **1280**. In one embodiment, the local communication module **1280** is a Bluetooth LE chip and associated software, although the underlying principles of the invention are not limited to any particular protocol standard. Once the pairing code is received, it is stored in a secure storage containing pairing data **1285** and the IoT device **101** and IoT hub **110** are automatically paired. Each time the IoT hub is paired with a new IoT device in this manner, the pairing data for that pairing is stored within the secure storage **685**. In one embodiment, once the local communication module **1280** of the IoT hub **110** receives the pairing code, it may use the code as a key to encrypt communications over the local wireless channel with the IoT device **101**. [0125] Similarly, on the IoT device **101** side, the local communication module **1590** stores pairing data within a local secure storage device **1595** indicating the pairing with the IoT hub. The pairing data **1295** may include the pre-programmed pairing code identified in the barcode/QR code **1201**. The pairing data **1295** may also include pairing data received from the local communication module **1280** on the IoT hub **110** required for establishing a secure local communication channel (e.g., an additional key to encrypt communication with the IoT hub **110**).

[0126] Thus, the barcode/QR code **1201** may be used to perform local pairing in a far more secure manner than current wireless pairing protocols because the pairing code is not transmitted over the air. In addition, in one embodiment, the same barcode/QR code **1201** used for pairing may be used to identify encryption keys to build a secure connection from the IoT device **101** to the IoT hub **110** and from the IoT hub **110** to the IoT service **120**.

[0127] A method for programming a SIM card in accordance with one embodiment of the invention is illustrated in FIG. 13. The method may be implemented within the system architecture described above, but is not limited to any particular system architecture.

[0128] At **1301**, a user receives a new IoT device with a blank SIM card and, at **1602**, the user inserts the blank SIM card into an IoT hub. At **1303**, the user programs the blank SIM card with a set of one or more encryption keys. For example, as mentioned above, in one embodiment, the IoT hub may randomly generate a public/private key pair and store the private key on the SIM card and the public key in its local secure storage. In addition, at **1304**, at least the public key is transmitted to the IoT service so that it may be used to identify the IoT device and establish encrypted communication with the IoT device. As mentioned above, in one embodiment, a programmable device other than a “SIM” card may be used to perform the same functions as the SIM card in the method shown in FIG. 13.

[0129] A method for integrating a new IoT device into a network is illustrated in FIG. 14. The method may be implemented within the system architecture described above, but is not limited to any particular system architecture.

[0130] At **1401**, a user receives a new IoT device to which an encryption key has been pre-assigned. At **1402**, the key is securely provided to the IoT hub. As mentioned above, in one embodiment, this involves reading a barcode associated with the IoT device to identify the public key of a public/private key pair assigned to the device. The barcode may be read directly by the IoT hub or captured via a mobile device via an app or browser. In an alternate embodiment, a secure communication channel such as a Bluetooth LE channel, a near field communication (NFC) channel or a secure WiFi channel may be established between the IoT device and the IoT hub to exchange the key. Regardless of how the key is transmitted, once received, it is stored in the secure keystore of the IoT hub device. As mentioned above, various secure execution technologies may be used on the IoT hub to store and protect the key such as Secure Enclaves, Trusted Execution

Technology (TXT), and/or Trustzone. In addition, at **803**, the key is securely transmitted to the IoT service which stores the key in its own secure keystore. It may then use the key to encrypt communication with the IoT device. One again, the exchange may be implemented using a certificate/signed key. Within the hub **110** it is particularly important to prevent modification/addition/removal of the stored keys.

[0131] A method for securely communicating commands/data to an IoT device using public/private keys is illustrated in FIG. **15**. The method may be implemented within the system architecture described above, but is not limited to any particular system architecture.

[0132] At **1501**, the IoT service encrypts the data/commands using the IoT device public key to create an IoT device packet. It then encrypts the IoT device packet using IoT hub's public key to create the IoT hub packet (e.g., creating an IoT hub wrapper around the IoT device packet). At **1502**, the IoT service transmits the IoT hub packet to the IoT hub. At **1503**, the IoT hub decrypts the IoT hub packet using the IoT hub's private key to generate the IoT device packet. At **1504** it then transmits the IoT device packet to the IoT device which, at **1505**, decrypts the IoT device packet using the IoT device private key to generate the data/commands. At **1506**, the IoT device processes the data/commands.

[0133] In an embodiment which uses symmetric keys, a symmetric key exchange may be negotiated between each of the devices (e.g., each device and the hub and between the hub and the service). Once the key exchange is complete, each transmitting device encrypts and/or signs each transmission using the symmetric key before transmitting data to the receiving device.

Apparatus and Method for Establishing Secure Communication Channels in an Internet of Things (IoT) System

[0134] In one embodiment of the invention, encryption and decryption of data is performed between the IoT service **120** and each IoT device **101**, regardless of the intermediate devices used to support the communication channel (e.g., such as the user's mobile device **611** and/or the IoT hub **110**). One embodiment which communicates via an IoT hub **110** is illustrated in FIG. **16A** and another embodiment which does not require an IoT hub is illustrated in FIG. **16B**.

[0135] Turning first to FIG. **16A**, the IoT service **120** includes an encryption engine **1660** which manages a set of “service session keys” **1650** and each IoT device **101** includes an encryption engine **1661** which manages a set of “device session keys” **1651** for encrypting/decrypting communication between the IoT device **101** and IoT service **120**. The encryption engines may rely on different hardware modules when performing the security/encryption techniques described herein including a hardware security module **1630-1631** for (among other things) generating a session public/private key pair and preventing access to the private session key of the pair and a key stream generation module **1640-1641** for generating a key stream using a derived secret. In one embodiment, the service session keys **1650** and the device session keys **1651** comprise related public/private key pairs. For example, in one embodiment, the device session keys **1651** on the IoT device **101** include a public key of the IoT service **120** and a private key of the IoT device **101**. As discussed in detail below, in one embodiment, to establish a secure communication session, the public/private session key pairs, **1650** and **1651**, are used by each encryption engine, **1660** and **1661**, respectively, to generate the same secret which is then used by the SKGMs **1640-1641** to generate a key stream to encrypt and decrypt communication between the IoT service **120** and the IoT device **101**. Additional details associated with generation and use of the secret in accordance with one embodiment of the invention are provided below.

[0136] In FIG. **16A**, once the secret has been generated using the keys **1650-1651**, the client will always send messages to the IoT device **101** through the IoT service **120**, as indicated by Clear transaction **1611**. “Clear” as used herein is meant to indicate that the underlying message is not encrypted using the encryption techniques described herein. However, as illustrated, in one embodiment, a secure sockets layer (SSL) channel or other secure channel (e.g., an Internet Protocol Security (IPSEC) channel) is established between the client device **611** and IoT service

120 to protect the communication. The encryption engine **1660** on the IoT service **120** then encrypts the message using the generated secret and transmits the encrypted message to the IoT hub **110** at **1602**. Rather than using the secret to encrypt the message directly, in one embodiment, the secret and a counter value are used to generate a key stream, which is used to encrypt each message packet. Details of this embodiment are described below with respect to FIG. 17.

[0137] As illustrated, an SSL connection or other secure channel may be established between the IoT service **120** and the IoT hub **110**. The IoT hub **110** (which does not have the ability to decrypt the message in one embodiment) transmits the encrypted message to the IoT device at **1603** (e.g., over a Bluetooth Low Energy (BTLE) communication channel). The encryption engine **1661** on the IoT device **101** may then decrypt the message using the secret and process the message contents. In an embodiment which uses the secret to generate a key stream, the encryption engine **1661** may generate the key stream using the secret and a counter value and then use the key stream for decryption of the message packet.

[0138] The message itself may comprise any form of communication between the IoT service **120** and IoT device **101**. For example, the message may comprise a command packet instructing the IoT device **101** to perform a particular function such as taking a measurement and reporting the result back to the client device **611** or may include configuration data to configure the operation of the IoT device **101**.

[0139] If a response is required, the encryption engine **1661** on the IoT device **101** uses the secret or a derived key stream to encrypt the response and transmits the encrypted response to the IoT hub **110** at **1604**, which forwards the response to the IoT service **120** at **1605**. The encryption engine **1660** on the IoT service **120** then decrypts the response using the secret or a derived key stream and transmits the decrypted response to the client device **611** at **1606** (e.g., over the SSL or other secure communication channel).

[0140] FIG. 16B illustrates an embodiment which does not require an IoT hub. Rather, in this embodiment, communication between the IoT device **101** and IoT service **120** occurs through the client device **611** (e.g., as in the embodiments described above with respect to FIGS. 6-9B). In this embodiment, to transmit a message to the IoT device **101** the client device **611** transmits an unencrypted version of the message to the IoT service **120** at **1611**. The encryption engine **1660** encrypts the message using the secret or the derived key stream and transmits the encrypted message back to the client device **611** at **1612**. The client device **611** then forwards the encrypted message to the IoT device **101** at **1613**, and the encryption engine **1661** decrypts the message using the secret or the derived key stream. The IoT device **101** may then process the message as described herein. If a response is required, the encryption engine **1661** encrypts the response using the secret and transmits the encrypted response to the client device **611** at **1614**, which forwards the encrypted response to the IoT service **120** at **1615**. The encryption engine **1660** then decrypts the response and transmits the decrypted response to the client device **611** at **1616**.

[0141] FIG. 17 illustrates a key exchange and key stream generation which may initially be performed between the IoT service **120** and the IoT device **101**. In one embodiment, this key exchange may be performed each time the IoT service **120** and IoT device **101** establish a new communication session. Alternatively, the key exchange may be performed and the exchanged session keys may be used for a specified period of time (e.g., a day, a week, etc). While no intermediate devices are shown in FIG. 17 for simplicity, communication may occur through the IoT hub **110** and/or the client device **611**.

[0142] In one embodiment, the encryption engine **1660** of the IoT service **120** sends a command to the HSM **1630** (e.g., which may be such as a CloudHSM offered by Amazon®) to generate a session public/private key pair. The HSM **1630** may subsequently prevent access to the private session key of the pair. Similarly, the encryption engine on the IoT device **101** may transmit a command to the HSM **1631** (e.g., such as an Atecc508 HSM from Atmel Corporation®) which generates a session public/private key pair and prevents access to the session private key of the

pair. Of course, the underlying principles of the invention are not limited to any specific type of encryption engine or manufacturer.

[0143] In one embodiment, the IoT service **120** transmits its session public key generated using the HSM **1630** to the IoT device **101** at **1701**. The IoT device uses its HSM **1631** to generate its own session public/private key pair and, at **1702**, transmits its public key of the pair to the IoT service **120**. In one embodiment, the encryption engines **1660-1661** use an Elliptic curve Diffie-Hellman (ECDH) protocol, which is an anonymous key agreement that allows two parties with an elliptic curve public-private key pair, to establish a shared secret. In one embodiment, using these techniques, at **1703**, the encryption engine **1660** of the IoT service **120** generates the secret using the IoT device session public key and its own session private key. Similarly, at **1704**, the encryption engine **1661** of the IoT device **101** independently generates the same secret using the IoT service **120** session public key and its own session private key. More specifically, in one embodiment, the encryption engine **1660** on the IoT service **120** generates the secret according to the formula $\text{secret} = \text{IoT device session pub key} * \text{IoT service session private key}$, where ‘*’ means that the IoT device session public key is point-multiplied by the IoT service session private key. The encryption engine **1661** on the IoT device **101** generates the secret according to the formula $\text{secret} = \text{IoT service session pub key} * \text{IoT device session private key}$, where the IoT service session public key is point multiplied by the IoT device session private key. In the end, the IoT service **120** and IoT device **101** have both generated the same secret to be used to encrypt communication as described below. In one embodiment, the encryption engines **1660-1661** rely on a hardware module such as the KSGMs **1640-1641** respectively to perform the above operations for generating the secret.

[0144] Once the secret has been determined, it may be used by the encryption engines **1660** and **1661** to encrypt and decrypt data directly. Alternatively, in one embodiment, the encryption engines **1660-1661** send commands to the KSGMs **1640-1641** to generate a new key stream using the secret to encrypt/decrypt each data packet (i.e., a new key stream data structure is generated for each packet). In particular, one embodiment of the key stream generation module **1640-1641** implements a Galois/Counter Mode (GCM) in which a counter value is incremented for each data packet and is used in combination with the secret to generate the key stream. Thus, to transmit a data packet to the IoT service **120**, the encryption engine **1661** of the IoT device **101** uses the secret and the current counter value to cause the KSGMs **1640-1641** to generate a new key stream and increment the counter value for generating the next key stream. The newly-generated key stream is then used to encrypt the data packet prior to transmission to the IoT service **120**. In one embodiment, the key stream is XORed with the data to generate the encrypted data packet. In one embodiment, the IoT device **101** transmits the counter value with the encrypted data packet to the IoT service **120**. The encryption engine **1660** on the IoT service then communicates with the KSGM **1640** which uses the received counter value and the secret to generate the key stream (which should be the same key stream because the same secret and counter value are used) and uses the generated key stream to decrypt the data packet.

[0145] In one embodiment, data packets transmitted from the IoT service **120** to the IoT device **101** are encrypted in the same manner. Specifically, a counter is incremented for each data packet and used along with the secret to generate a new key stream. The key stream is then used to encrypt the data (e.g., performing an XOR of the data and the key stream) and the encrypted data packet is transmitted with the counter value to the IoT device **101**. The encryption engine **1661** on the IoT device **101** then communicates with the KSGM **1641** which uses the counter value and the secret to generate the same key stream which is used to decrypt the data packet. Thus, in this embodiment, the encryption engines **1660-1661** use their own counter values to generate a key stream to encrypt data and use the counter values received with the encrypted data packets to generate a key stream to decrypt the data.

[0146] In one embodiment, each encryption engine **1660-1661** keeps track of the last counter value it received from the other and includes sequencing logic to detect whether a counter value is

received out of sequence or if the same counter value is received more than once. If a counter value is received out of sequence, or if the same counter value is received more than once, this may indicate that a replay attack is being attempted. In response, the encryption engines **1660-1661** may disconnect from the communication channel and/or may generate a security alert.

[0147] FIG. **18** illustrates an exemplary encrypted data packet employed in one embodiment of the invention comprising a 4-byte counter value **1800**, a variable-sized encrypted data field **1801**, and a 6-byte tag **1802**. In one embodiment, the tag **1802** comprises a checksum value to validate the decrypted data (once it has been decrypted).

[0148] As mentioned, in one embodiment, the session public/private key pairs **1650-1651** exchanged between the IoT service **120** and IoT device **101** may be generated periodically and/or in response to the initiation of each new communication session.

[0149] One embodiment of the invention implements additional techniques for authenticating sessions between the IoT service **120** and IoT device **101**. In particular, in one embodiment, hierarchy of public/private key pairs is used including a master key pair, a set of factory key pairs, and a set of IoT service key pairs, and a set of IoT device key pairs. In one embodiment, the master key pair comprises a root of trust for all of the other key pairs and is maintained in a single, highly secure location (e.g., under the control of the organization implementing the IoT systems described herein). The master private key may be used to generate signatures over (and thereby authenticate) various other key pairs such as the factory key pairs. The signatures may then be verified using the master public key. In one embodiment, each factory which manufactures IoT devices is assigned its own factory key pair which may then be used to authenticate IoT service keys and IoT device keys. For example, in one embodiment, a factory private key is used to generate a signature over IoT service public keys and IoT device public keys. These signature may then be verified using the corresponding factory public key. Note that these IoT service/device public keys are not the same as the “session” public/private keys described above with respect to FIGS. **16A-B**. The session public/private keys described above are temporary (i.e., generated for a service/device session) while the IoT service/device key pairs are permanent (i.e., generated at the factory).

[0150] With the foregoing relationships between master keys, factory keys, service/device keys in mind, one embodiment of the invention performs the following operations to provide additional layers of authentication and security between the IoT service **120** and IoT device **101**: [0151] A. In one embodiment, the IoT service **120** initially generates a message containing the following: [0152] 1. The IoT service's unique ID: [0153] The IoT service's serial number; [0154] a Timestamp; [0155] The ID of the factory key used to sign this unique ID; [0156] a Class of the unique ID (i.e., a service); [0157] IoT service's public key [0158] The signature over the unique ID. [0159] 2. The Factory Certificate including: [0160] A timestamp [0161] The ID of the master key used to sign the certificate [0162] The factory public key [0163] The signature of the Factory Certificate [0164] 3. IoT service session public key (as described above with respect to FIGS. **16A-B**) [0165] 4. IoT service session public key signature (e.g., signed with the IoT service's private key) [0166] B. In one embodiment, the message is sent to the IoT device on the negotiation channel (described below). The IoT device parses the message and: [0167] 1. Verifies the signature of the factory certificate (only if present in the message payload) [0168] 2. Verifies the signature of the unique ID using the key identified by the unique ID [0169] 3. Verifies the IoT service session public key signature using the IoT service's public key from the unique ID [0170] 4. Saves the IoT service's public key as well as the IoT service's session public key [0171] 5. Generates the IoT device session key pair [0172] C. The IoT device then generates a message containing the following: [0173] 1. IoT device's unique ID [0174] IoT device serial number [0175] Timestamp [0176] ID of factory key used to sign this unique ID [0177] Class of unique ID (i.e., IoT device) [0178] IoT device's public key [0179] Signature of unique ID [0180] 2. IoT device's session public key [0181] 3. Signature of (IoT device session public key+IoT service session public key) signed with IoT device's key [0182] D. This message is sent back to the IoT service. The IoT service parses the

message and: [0183] 1. Verifies the signature of the unique ID using the factory public key [0184] 2. Verifies the signature of the session public keys using the IoT device's public key [0185] 3. Saves the IoT device's session public key [0186] E. The IoT service then generates a message containing a signature of (IoT device session public key+IoT service session public key) signed with the IoT service's key. [0187] F. The IoT device parses the message and: [0188] 1. Verifies the signature of the session public keys using the IoT service's public key [0189] 2. Generates the key stream from the IoT device session private key and the IoT service's session public key [0190] 3. The IoT device then sends a “messaging available” message. [0191] G. The IoT service then does the following: [0192] 1. Generates the key stream from the IoT service session private key and the IoT device's session public key [0193] 2. Creates a new message on the messaging channel which contains the following: [0194] Generates and stores a random 2 byte value [0195] Set attribute message with the boomerang attribute Id (discussed below) and the random value [0196] H. The IoT device receives the message and: [0197] 1. Attempts to decrypt the message [0198] 2. Emits an Update with the same value on the indicated attribute Id [0199] I. The IoT service recognizes the message payload contains a boomerang attribute update and: [0200] 1. Sets its paired state to true [0201] 2. Sends a pairing complete message on the negotiator channel [0202] J. IoT device receives the message and sets his paired state to true

[0203] While the above techniques are described with respect to an “IoT service” and an “IoT device,” the underlying principles of the invention may be implemented to establish a secure communication channel between any two devices including user client devices, servers, and Internet services.

[0204] The above techniques are highly secure because the private keys are never shared over the air (in contrast to current Bluetooth pairing techniques in which a secret is transmitted from one party to the other). An attacker listening to the entire conversation will only have the public keys, which are insufficient to generate the shared secret. These techniques also prevent a man-in-the-middle attack by exchanging signed public keys. In addition, because GCM and separate counters are used on each device, any kind of “replay attack” (where a man in the middle captures the data and sends it again) is prevented. Some embodiments also prevent replay attacks by using asymmetrical counters.

Techniques for Exchanging Data and Commands without Formally Pairing Devices

[0205] GATT is an acronym for the Generic Attribute Profile, and it defines the way that two Bluetooth Low Energy (BTLE) devices transfer data back and forth. It makes use of a generic data protocol called the Attribute Protocol (ATT), which is used to store Services, Characteristics and related data in a simple lookup table using 16-bit Characteristic IDs for each entry in the table. Note that while the “characteristics” are sometimes referred to as “attributes.”

[0206] On Bluetooth devices, the most commonly used characteristic is the devices “name” (having characteristic ID 10752 (0x2A00)). For example, a Bluetooth device may identify other Bluetooth devices within its vicinity by reading the “Name” characteristic published by those other Bluetooth devices using GATT. Thus, Bluetooth device have the inherent ability to exchange data without formally pairing/bonding the devices (note that “paring” and “bonding” are sometimes used interchangeably; the remainder of this discussion will use the term “pairing”).

[0207] One embodiment of the invention takes advantage of this capability to communicate with BTLE-enabled IoT devices without formally pairing with these devices. Pairing with each individual IoT device would extremely inefficient because of the amount of time required to pair with each device and because only one paired connection may be established at a time.

[0208] FIG. 19 illustrates one particular embodiment in which a Bluetooth (BT) device 1910 establishes a network socket abstraction with a BT communication module 1901 of an IoT device 101 without formally establishing a paired BT connection. The BT device 1910 may be included in an IoT hub 110 and/or a client device 611 such as shown in FIG. 16A. As illustrated, the BT communication module 1901 maintains a data structure containing a list of characteristic IDs,

names associated with those characteristic IDs and values for those characteristic IDs. The value for each characteristic may be stored within a 20-byte buffer identified by the characteristic ID in accordance with the current BT standard. However, the underlying principles of the invention are not limited to any particular buffer size.

[0209] In the example in FIG. 19, the “Name” characteristic is a BT-defined characteristic which is assigned a specific value of “IoT Device 14.” One embodiment of the invention specifies a first set of additional characteristics to be used for negotiating a secure communication channel with the BT device 1910 and a second set of additional characteristics to be used for encrypted communication with the BT device 1910. In particular, a “negotiation write” characteristic, identified by characteristic ID <65532> in the illustrated example, may be used to transmit outgoing negotiation messages and the “negotiation read” characteristic, identified by characteristic ID <65533> may be used to receive incoming negotiation messages. The “negotiation messages” may include messages used by the BT device 1910 and the BT communication module 1901 to establish a secure communication channel as described herein. By way of example, in FIG. 17, the IoT device 101 may receive the IoT service session public key 1701 via the “negotiation read” characteristic <65533>. The key 1701 may be transmitted from the IoT service 120 to a BTLE-enabled IoT hub 110 or client device 611 which may then use GATT to write the key 1701 to the negotiation read value buffer identified by characteristic ID <65533>. IoT device application logic 1902 may then read the key 1701 from the value buffer identified by characteristic ID <65533> and process it as described above (e.g., using it to generate a secret and using the secret to generate a key stream, etc).

[0210] If the key 1701 is greater than 20 bytes (the maximum buffer size in some current implementations), then it may be written in 20-byte portions. For example, the first 20 bytes may be written by the BT communication module 1903 to characteristic ID <65533> and read by the IoT device application logic 1902, which may then write an acknowledgement message to the negotiation write value buffer identified by characteristic ID <65532>. Using GATT, the BT communication module 1903 may read this acknowledgement from characteristic ID <65532> and responsively write the next 20 bytes of the key 1701 to the negotiation read value buffer identified by characteristic ID <65533>. In this manner, a network socket abstraction defined by characteristic IDs <65532> and <65533> is established for exchanging negotiation messages used to establish a secure communication channel.

[0211] In one embodiment, once the secure communication channel is established, a second network socket abstraction is established using characteristic ID <65534> (for transmitting encrypted data packets from IoT device 101) and characteristic ID <65533> (for receiving encrypted data packets by IoT device). That is, when BT communication module 1903 has an encrypted data packet to transmit (e.g., such as encrypted message 1603 in FIG. 16A), it starts writing the encrypted data packet, 20 bytes at a time, using the message read value buffer identified by characteristic ID <65533>. The IoT device application logic 1902 will then read the encrypted data packet, 20 bytes at a time, from the read value buffer, sending acknowledgement messages to the BT communication module 1903 as needed via the write value buffer identified by characteristic ID <65532>.

[0212] In one embodiment, the commands of GET, SET, and UPDATE described below are used to exchange data and commands between the two BT communication modules 1901 and 1903. For example, the BT communication module 1903 may send a packet identifying characteristic ID <65533> and containing the SET command to write into the value field/buffer identified by characteristic ID <65533> which may then be read by the IoT device application logic 1902. To retrieve data from the IoT device 101, the BT communication module 1903 may transmit a GET command directed to the value field/buffer identified by characteristic ID <65534>. In response to the GET command, the BT communication module 1901 may transmit an UPDATE packet to the BT communication module 1903 containing the data from the value field/buffer identified by

characteristic ID <65534>. In addition, UPDATE packets may be transmitted automatically, in response to changes in a particular attribute on the IoT device **101**. For example, if the IoT device is associated with a lighting system and the user turns on the lights, then an UPDATE packet may be sent to reflect the change to the on/off attribute associated with the lighting application.

[0213] FIG. **20** illustrates exemplary packet formats used for GET, SET, and UPDATE in accordance with one embodiment of the invention. In one embodiment, these packets are transmitted over the message write <65534> and message read <65533> channels following negotiation. In the GET packet **2001**, a first 1-byte field includes a value (0X10) which identifies the packet as a GET packet. A second 1-byte field includes a request ID, which uniquely identifies the current GET command (i.e., identifies the current transaction with which the GET command is associated). For example, each instance of a GET command transmitted from a service or device may be assigned a different request ID. This may be done, for example, by incrementing a counter and using the counter value as the request ID. However, the underlying principles of the invention are not limited to any particular manner for setting the request ID.

[0214] A 2-byte attribute ID identifies the application-specific attribute to which the packet is directed. For example, if the GET command is being sent to IoT device **101** illustrated in FIG. **19**, the attribute ID may be used to identify the particular application-specific value being requested. Returning to the above example, the GET command may be directed to an application-specific attribute ID such as power status of a lighting system, which comprises a value identifying whether the lights are powered on or off (e.g., 1=on, 0=off). If the IoT device **101** is a security apparatus associated with a door, then the value field may identify the current status of the door (e.g., 1=opened, 0=closed). In response to the GET command, a response may be transmitting containing the current value identified by the attribute ID.

[0215] The SET packet **2002** and UPDATE packet **2003** illustrated in FIG. **20** also include a first 1-byte field identifying the type of packet (i.e., SET and UPDATE), a second 1-byte field containing a request ID, and a 2-byte attribute ID field identifying an application-defined attribute. In addition, the SET packet includes a 2-byte length value identifying the length of data contained in an n-byte value data field. The value data field may include a command to be executed on the IoT device and/or configuration data to configure the operation of the IoT device in some manner (e.g., to set a desired parameter, to power down the IoT device, etc). For example, if the IoT device **101** controls the speed of a fan, the value field may reflect the current fan speed.

[0216] The UPDATE packet **2003** may be transmitted to provide an update of the results of the SET command. The UPDATE packet **2003** includes a 2-byte length value field to identify the length of the n-byte value data field which may include data related to the results of the SET command. In addition, a 1-byte update state field may identify the current state of the variable being updated. For example, if the SET command attempted to turn off a light controlled by the IoT device, the update state field may indicate whether the light was successfully turned off.

[0217] FIG. **21** illustrates an exemplary sequence of transactions between the IoT service **120** and an IoT device **101** involving the SET and UPDATE commands. Intermediary devices such as the IoT hub and the user's mobile device are not shown to avoid obscuring the underlying principles of the invention. At **2101**, the SET command **2101** is transmitted from the IoT service to the IoT device **101** and received by the BT communication module **1901** which responsively updates the GATT value buffer identified by the characteristic ID at **2102**. The SET command is read from the value buffer by the low power microcontroller (MCU) **200** at **2103** (or by program code being executed on the low power MCU such as IoT device application logic **1902** shown in FIG. **19**). At **2104**, the MCU **200** or program code performs an operation in response to the SET command. For example, the SET command may include an attribute ID specifying a new configuration parameter such as a new temperature or may include a state value such as on/off (to cause the IoT device to enter into an "on" or a low power state). Thus, at **2104**, the new value is set in the IoT device and an UPDATE command is returned at **2105** and the actual value is updated in a GATT value field at

2106. In some cases, the actual value will be equal to the desired value. In other cases, the updated value may be different (i.e., because it may take time for the IoT device **101** to update certain types of values). Finally, at **2107**, the UPDATE command is transmitted back to the IoT service **120** containing the actual value from the GATT value field.

[0218] FIG. **22** illustrates a method for implementing a secure communication channel between an IoT service and an IoT device in accordance with one embodiment of the invention. The method may be implemented within the context of the network architectures described above but is not limited to any specific architecture.

[0219] At **2201**, the IoT service creates an encrypted channel to communicate with the IoT hub using elliptic curve digital signature algorithm (ECDSA) certificates. At **2202**, the IoT service encrypts data/commands in IoT device packets using the a session secret to create an encrypted device packet. As mentioned above, the session secret may be independently generated by the IoT device and the IoT service. At **2203**, the IoT service transmits the encrypted device packet to the IoT hub over the encrypted channel. At **2204**, without decrypting, the IoT hub passes the encrypted device packet to the IoT device. At **2205**, the IoT device uses the session secret to decrypt the encrypted device packet. As mentioned, in one embodiment this may be accomplished by using the secret and a counter value (provided with the encrypted device packet) to generate a key stream and then using the key stream to decrypt the packet. At **2206**, the IoT device then extracts and processes the data and/or commands contained within the device packet.

[0220] Thus, using the above techniques, bi-directional, secure network socket abstractions may be established between two BT-enabled devices without formally pairing the BT devices using standard pairing techniques. While these techniques are described above with respect to an IoT device **101** communicating with an IoT service **120**, the underlying principles of the invention may be implemented to negotiate and establish a secure communication channel between any two BT-enabled devices.

[0221] FIGS. **23A-C** illustrate a detailed method for pairing devices in accordance with one embodiment of the invention. The method may be implemented within the context of the system architectures described above, but is not limited to any specific system architectures.

[0222] At **2301**, the IoT Service creates a packet containing serial number and public key of the IoT Service. At **2302**, the IoT Service signs the packet using the factory private key. At **2303**, the IoT Service sends the packet over an encrypted channel to the IoT hub and at **2304** the IoT hub forwards the packet to IoT device over an unencrypted channel. At **2305**, the IoT device verifies the signature of packet and, at **2306**, the IoT device generates a packet containing the serial number and public key of the IoT Device. At **2307**, the IoT device signs the packet using the factory private key and at **2308**, the IoT device sends the packet over the unencrypted channel to the IoT hub.

[0223] At **2309**, the IoT hub forwards the packet to the IoT service over an encrypted channel and at **2310**, the IoT Service verifies the signature of the packet. At **2311**, the IoT Service generates a session key pair, and at **2312** the IoT Service generates a packet containing the session public key. The IoT Service then signs the packet with IoT Service private key at **2313** and, at **2314**, the IoT Service sends the packet to the IoT hub over the encrypted channel.

[0224] Turning to FIG. **23B**, the IoT hub forwards the packet to the IoT device over the unencrypted channel at **2315** and, at **2316**, the IoT device verifies the signature of packet. At **2317** the IoT device generates session key pair (e.g., using the techniques described above), and, at **2318**, an IoT device packet is generated containing the IoT device session public key. At **2319**, the IoT device signs the IoT device packet with IoT device private key. At **2320**, the IoT device sends the packet to the IoT hub over the unencrypted channel and, at **2321**, the IoT hub forwards the packet to the IoT service over an encrypted channel.

[0225] At **2322**, the IoT service verifies the signature of the packet (e.g., using the IoT device public key) and, at **2323**, the IoT service uses the IoT service private key and the IoT device public key to generate the session secret (as described in detail above). At **2324**, the IoT device uses the

IoT device private key and IoT service public key to generate the session secret (again, as described above) and, at **2325**, the IoT device generates a random number and encrypts it using the session secret. At **2326**, the IoT service sends the encrypted packet to IoT hub over the encrypted channel. At **2327**, the IoT hub forwards the encrypted packet to the IoT device over the unencrypted channel. At **2328**, the IoT device decrypts the packet using the session secret.

[0226] Turning to FIG. **23C**, the IoT device re-encrypts the packet using the session secret at **2329** and, at **2330**, the IoT device sends the encrypted packet to the IoT hub over the unencrypted channel. At **2331**, the IoT hub forwards the encrypted packet to the IoT service over the encrypted channel. The IoT service decrypts the packet using the session secret at **2332**. At **2333** the IoT service verifies that the random number matches the random number it sent. The IoT service then sends a packet indicating that pairing is complete at **2334** and all subsequent messages are encrypted using the session secret at **2335**.

Apparatus and Method for Cryptographically Securing Unpowered or Non-Electronic IoT Devices [0227] Attestation of providence and of single use is necessary for a large class of products including, by way of example, and not limitation, home medical testing kits and digital tax stamps for controlled substances. However, because many of these products are non-electronic, vigorous attestation can be challenging. Embodiments of the invention include techniques for securely attesting such products using key-based signatures and a defined chain of trust.

[0228] The embodiments described above provide cryptographic protections for IoT devices using a Public Key Infrastructure which relies on a chain of trust. In some of these embodiments IoT devices can transmit data to communicate their identity as well as a device certificate that is signed by a which, in turn, was signed by any number of devices in a chain, up to a common Root key. For example, in FIGS. **23A-C**, a factory private key is used to cryptographically secure communication between an IoT device and the IoT service. In particular, at **2302**, the IoT service signs an outgoing packet using the factory private key and at **2307**, the IoT device signs an outgoing packet using the factory private key. These operations form a portion of a larger sequence of transactions for generating a session secret to encrypt communication between the IoT device and the IoT service. Thus, this sequence of operations rely on an operational, connected IoT device.

[0229] In these embodiments, the certificate chain can be traversed to validate that the device is authentic. In addition, these embodiments rely on a well-defined factory provisioning process which produces a record of devices that can be compared against when a device is interacted with.

[0230] Embodiments of the invention perform a modified series of transactions to cryptographically secure inactive or non-electronic devices or products (sometimes referred to as “passive” products), while still relying on the chain of trust and aspects of the cryptographic framework described above. In this use case, only the authenticity of the passive product needs to be verified because the dataflow is only from the passive product to the IoT service.

[0231] A sufficient amount of cryptographic information is encoded in a machine-readable optical code (e.g., QR code or barcode) on the passive product for the mobile app and/or the IoT service to identify and verify the authenticity of the product. Because factories are not perfect at maintaining and delivering factory logs, these embodiments can do so even in the event of the occasional missed product to ensure an acceptable customer experience, while still ensuring that the factory did, in fact, produce the passive product device in question.

[0232] Referring to FIG. **24**, one embodiment of the invention operates in accordance with the following sequence of operations to authenticate a passive product **2401**. By way of example, and not limitation, the passive product **2401** may be medical test kit used to test for an infectious disease. As such, the test kit must be validated to confirm that it has not been previously used.

[0233] From the mobile app on the user's device **135** (which may be the same as the IoT device app described herein), the machine-readable optical label **2405** (e.g., a 2D barcode) is scanned and the resulting code **2460** is transmitted to a security module **2450** on the IoT service **120**. As mentioned, the client device **135** may initially establish a secure communication channel with the IoT service

120 (e.g., an SSL channel).

[0234] The security module **2450** attempts to verify the code **2460** extracted from the optical label **2405**. A code validation module **2455** may initially query the product database **2451** to determine if the code **2460** has previously been used. In one embodiment, as soon as a particular product has been used, the database **2451** is updated accordingly—and the same product can not be used more than once. Thus, if the product has been previously used, the validation result **2462** transmitted to the user device **135** informs the user of the error and prevents recording of any test result.

[0235] If the code **2460** passes the “prior use” check, then a digital signature check is performed, to confirm that a signature included with the code **2460** is valid. For example, the code validation module **2455** may regenerate the signature over the product ID and other metadata initially used to generate the signature, to determine whether the signature is valid. If the signature check fails, then the validation result **2462** will indicate a failure on a digital signature check; the user will be informed that the test is invalid and should not be used.

[0236] If, however, the code **2460** passes both the prior use check and the signature validation, then the security module **2450** will mark it as used in the database **2451** so that it cannot be reused. The validation result **2462** will then indicate to the user that the test is valid and can be used.

[0237] Additional details associated with the code **2460**, including the signature, encoded in the machine-readable optical code are provided below. FIG. **25** illustrates the chain of trust used to generate signatures on various forms of products **2530-2531**, including non-electronic, “passive” products described herein. A root of trust **2500** includes a secret key used to generate a signature on a factory-factory authentication device key **2510**, which is used as the cryptographic root of trust at a particular factory. The factory-factory authenticator **2510** is sometimes referred to herein as the “level 1” factory authenticator. The factory-factory device key **2510** may be used to generate signatures over one or more keys of factory authenticator devices **2520**, or “level 2” factory authenticators, which are used on the floor of the factory to generate signatures on the various products **2530-2531**.

[0238] FIG. **26** illustrates additional details of the operations performed by the factory authenticator **2520** to generate the optical label **2405** for a product **2530**, allowing the product **2530** to be cryptographically validated. In various embodiments, the factory authenticator **2520** may be a data processing device with a CPU (or other processor) and memory for executing the authentication operations described herein. The factory authenticator may also include dedicated hardware for performing these operations and for securely storing its assigned keys (e.g., a HSM device). A user interface may be provided to allow a factory worker to control the operations described herein.

[0239] In the illustrated embodiment, the universally unique identifier (UUID) generator **2600** generates a large random number to be used as a unique ID. The UUID is sufficiently large to ensure that it is statistically highly unlikely that there will ever be two devices assigned the same UUID (e.g., 128 bits).

[0240] In one embodiment, a signature generator **2630** of the factory authenticator **2520** uses the factory authenticator key **2620** to generate a signature over the UUID, a date stamp **2610**, and other specified metadata **2611** associated with the factory authenticator **2520**. For example, the metadata **2611** may include a unique identification code and/or hardware/software version associated with the authenticator **2520**. Various other forms of metadata may be combined with the UUID to generate the signature. Once generated, the signature may be encoded in the optical label **2405** along with the UUID. In one embodiment, the UUID, metadata, and signature are encoded in a 40×40 QR code; however, the underlying principles of the invention are not limited to this implementation.

[0241] As illustrated, the key **2620** is provided to the security module **2450** so that the code validation logic **2455** can subsequently validate the signature extracted from the optical label **2405** as described with respect to FIG. **24**. For example, the security module **2450** may regenerate the signature over the UUID and metadata using the key **2620** and validate the product **2530** if the

signatures match.

[0242] A method for cryptographically securing a product is illustrated in FIG. 27A and a method for validating the cryptographically secured product is illustrated in FIG. 27B. These methods may be executed in the context of the system architectures described above, but are not limited to any particular system architecture.

[0243] At **2701**, a factory authenticator is produced from an authentication device further up towards the root of trust (e.g., the factory-factory authenticator described above). At **2702**, a UUID is randomly generated and, at **2703**, a signature is generated over the UUID and factory authenticator metadata (e.g., version identifiers, date stamp, etc). At **2704**, the UUID, metadata, and signature are encoded in an optical label of the product.

[0244] At **2711** of FIG. 27B, the IoT app causes the mobile device to capture an image of the optical label to extract the UUID, metadata, and signature. At **2712**, the UUID, metadata and signature are transmitted to the IoT service and, at **2713**, the IoT service initially verifies that there has been no prior use of the product. This step is particularly important for at home medical test kits, which can only be used once.

[0245] Once it has been determined that the test kit has not been previously used, at **2714**, the IoT service validates the signature. For example, it may regenerate the signature with the same key and over the same data (e.g., the UUID and metadata) as used to generate the encoded signature. If the signatures match, then at **2715**, a message is sent to the IoT app that the product is valid and can be used.

[0246] The above techniques can be used to track and cryptographically validate any type of products, but may be particularly beneficial for certain types of products which require a heightened level of security, such as at-home medical testing kits, and digital tax stamps for controlled substances (e.g., alcohol, cannabis, etc). However, virtually any type of product tracking system can benefit from the authentication techniques described herein.

Apparatus and Method for Efficient and Secure Pairing and Communication

[0247] One embodiment of the invention includes mechanisms for securely pairing a Bluetooth peripheral with a computer or mobile device. In particular, a QR code generated by a factory authenticator, as described above, is used to uniquely identify a peripheral device to securely expedite the pairing process.

[0248] Referring to FIG. 28, in one embodiment, a QR code **2405** is captured by a camera **2802** of a data processing device **2820** to pair the peripheral device **2830** with the data processing device **2820**. In this embodiment, the data processing device executes an app **2801** associated with the IoT service **120** which includes a hub **2800** to communicatively couple the peripheral **2830** to the IoT service **120**. The IoT service **120** acts as an intermediary between the peripheral **2830** and the data processing device **2820** during the pairing process. In one implementation, the IoT service **120** includes a security subsystem **2450** which verifies the identity of the peripheral **2830** based on the QR code **2405** and validates the certificates generated by the peripheral device **2830** and the data processing device **2820**. A session key is then exchanged between the peripheral device **2830** and data processing device **2820** to establish a secure Bluetooth channel.

[0249] In operation, the Bluetooth interface **2850** of the peripheral **2830** establishes a link with the Bluetooth interface **2851** of the data processing device **2820**, allowing the peripheral **2830** to securely connect with the IoT service **120** via the hub **2800**. The code **2862** captured from the QR code **2405** with the camera **2802**, is provided by the hub **2800** to the IoT service **120**. Code validation logic **2455** validates the code **2862** using identification data related to the peripheral **2830** stored in the database **2451** (e.g., a Device ID, UUID, factory-generated keys, etc). As described above, the code **2862** may include a signature generated over a unique peripheral ID which can be verified by the code validation logic **2455**.

[0250] If the validation result **2462** indicates that the code **2862** is valid, then the security subsystem **2856** on the peripheral **2830** and security subsystem **2857** on the data processing device

2820 generate separate public/private key pairs and corresponding certificates (e.g., using a combination of the public key and device-specific data). For example, the security subsystem **2856** on the peripheral **2830** may combine the peripheral public key with the peripheral's MAC address and/or Device ID (or any other unique identifier) to generate the peripheral certificate and the security subsystem **2857** on the data processing device **2820** may combine the data processing device's public key with the device's MAC address and/or UUID to generate the data processing device certificate. Of course, various other information may be included in the certificates while still complying with the underlying principles of the invention.

[0251] The certificates are sent to the IoT service **120** where certificate validation logic **2875** validates and generates a signature over the certificates (e.g., signing the certificates with the IoT service private key) and returns the signed certificates to the peripheral device **2830** and data processing device **2820**. Once validated, the security subsystem **2856** of the peripheral and security subsystem **2857** of the data processing device **2820** use the key pairs to securely generate and share a secret, which is used to produce the session key for secure Bluetooth communication. For example, the peripheral security logic **2856** may generate the session key using its private key and the data processing device public key while the data processing device security logic **2857** may generate the session key using its private key and the peripheral public key.

[0252] In one implementation, the session key is then used by the Bluetooth driver **2852** to encrypt/decrypt communication. The Bluetooth driver **2852** may be a human interface device (HID) driver which provides for secure HID communication and translates to the normal HID driver format used for a particular operating system (e.g., Windows 11, MacOS, Linux, etc).

[0253] Thus, by using the IoT service **120** as a trusted intermediary, the peripheral device **2830** can be efficiently and securely paired with the data processing device **2820** simply by capturing the QR code **2405** provided on the peripheral **2830**. This is in contrast to current Bluetooth pairing implementations in which at least some unencrypted information is transmitted in the clear and which is a burdensome process for the end user.

[0254] FIG. **29** illustrates a sequence of transactions for pairing the peripheral **2830** with the data processing device **2820** in accordance with one implementation. Once the QR code **2405** has been verified (as described above), at **2901**, the peripheral generates a key pair and an associated certificate **2901** (e.g., using the public key and device-specific code(s)). Similarly, at **2902**, the data processing device **2820** generates a key pair and an associated certificate. At **2903** the peripheral certificate is transmitted to the IoT service **120** via the hub **2800** and, at **2904**, the data processing device certificate is transmitted to the IoT service **120**. At **2905**, the IoT service **120** validates and signs each of the certificates and sends back the signed certificates back to the data processing device **2820** (at **2906**) and peripheral **2830** (at **2907** via the hub **2800**).

[0255] Once the signatures are verified by the peripheral **2830** and data processing device **2820**, at **2908** and **2909**, respectively, they each generate a shared secret at **2910** and **2911**, respectively. For example, the peripheral **2830** may use its private key and the data processing device's public key to generate the secret and the data processing device **2820** may use its private key and the peripheral's public key to generate the secret. They each use the secret for a session key (either alone or in combination with other identification data) to establish a secure session at **2912**.

Apparatus and Method for Activation and Deactivation of Devices to Prevent Unauthorized Acquisition and Use

[0256] Embodiments of the invention leverage the service-based architecture described herein to prevent theft or unauthorized use of various types of devices (including but not limited to IoT devices). By way of example, and not limitation, when a user purchases a new device at a point of sale (POS) location, the POS system extracts the unique device ID generated in accordance with the implementations described herein and transmits a purchase message with the device ID to the IoT service. The IoT service identifies the device using the device ID and sets a corresponding flag in the device database indicating that the device has been successfully purchased.

[0257] FIG. 30 illustrates one embodiment in which a reader 3015 of a POS system 3020 acquires the device ID of a product/device 3000 by scanning and decoding the data matrix 3005 encoded on the product and/or the product packaging. The reader 3015 may alternatively or additionally be an RF-based reader, capable of reading the device ID from a radio frequency ID (RFID) tag incorporated in the product/device 3000 (or the product packaging) and/or may use near field communication (NFC) to acquire the device ID from the product/device 3000, depending on how the device ID is encoded in the product/device 3000. NFC uses communications protocols and data exchange formats based on radio-frequency identification (RFID) standards including ISO/IEC 14443 and FeliCa. Other embodiments of the invention may rely on other data communication protocols to read the device ID.

[0258] Regardless of how the device ID is acquired, sale processing logic 3050 at the POS terminal 3020 (which is pre-authenticated with the IoT service 2450) transmits a message 3050 to the IoT service 2450 (e.g., based on the API exposed by the IoT service 2450) including the device ID and indicating that the device was successfully purchased. Device management logic 3060 parses/reads the message 3050 and responsively sets the purchase flag associated with the device ID in the device database 3001 (e.g., DevID2 has its purchase flag set to 1 in the illustrated example).

[0259] In some embodiments, when a customer purchases the product at the POS 3020, the universal product code (UPC) 3071 is initially scanned. The cashier (or customer at a self-scan location) is then asked to scan the data matrix 3005 of the product to capture the device ID. Alternatively, the data contained in the UPC and data matrix may be combined into a single data matrix or barcode. If the reader 3015 includes RF capabilities such as NFC, then the reader 3015 may automatically capture the device ID when the SKU 3071 is scanned (e.g., using NFC, RFID, or other RF-based protocols). For example, scanning the SKU 3071 and/or bringing the product/device 3000 in the vicinity of the NFC transceiver may automatically trigger it to read the device ID. While a single reader 3015 is shown in FIG. 30 for simplicity, different implementations may include multiple different types of readers including optical readers and RF-based readers.

[0260] In one embodiment, the sale processing logic 3016 and/or IoT service 2450 tracks the SKUs 3071 assigned to the various device IDs (e.g., as indicated by the SKU column 3006 in the device database 3001 of the IoT service 2450). Using this association, the sale processing logic 3016 verifies that the device ID from the data matrix 3005 corresponds to the SKU 3071. If not, then it may generate a notification 3080 at the POS 3020 (e.g., displayed on the POS monitor) that additional steps may be required to associate the product 3000 with the SKU 3071 and/or register/activate the product with the IoT service 2450. In some cases, the POS 3020 may interrupt the purchase and/or require authorization to proceed by individual at the POS location.

[0261] Once the sale is completed, the sale processing logic 3016 calls the IoT service 120 via the API to set the purchase flag 3004 for all device IDs and/or SKUs 3071 captured during the sale process, thus moving them from store inventory to customer-owned in the device database 3001. The device management logic 3060 responsively sets the purchase flags 3004 for all device IDs received in the transaction.

[0262] In one embodiment, the POS system 3020 generates a verification code 3096 which the user may be prompted to enter when registering the product 3000 on the IoT service 2450 or otherwise activating the product 3000. The verification code 3096 may be provided on a printed receipt 3095 and/or sent electronically to the user (e.g., emailed, texted, associated with the user's account on a server, etc). If the IoT service 2450 does not have the device ID in its database 3001, and/or if the purchase flag 3004 is not set, and/or if the SKU is not correctly associated with the device ID, then the user may be prompted to scan or enter the verification code 3069 (e.g., via the user's mobile device 130) during the device registration or activation process.

[0263] When the customer subsequently attempts to add the product 3000 to their account on the IoT service 2450 using the IoT app on the mobile device 130 by scanning the data matrix 3005 or wirelessly capturing the device ID (e.g., via a BTLE connection), the device management logic

3060 on the IoT service **2450** verifies that the purchase flag **3004** has been set in the database **3001**. If it has, then the device **3000** is registered in the IoT service **2450** (e.g., using one or more of the techniques described herein for IoT device provisioning/registration).

[0264] If the purchase flag **3004** has been set, but the device ID is still not linked to a product SKU, then the IoT app on the mobile device **135** may prompt the user to scan or enter the verification code **3096** provided by the POS system **3020** or to scan or enter the SKU **3071**. Using this information, the device manager **3060** can link the device ID from the data matrix **3005** to the SKU **3071** in the device database **3001** and register the product/device **3000** with the IoT service **2450**.

[0265] In some instances, if the purchase flag **3004** for the device ID has not been set in the database **3001**, then the IoT app on the mobile device **135** will prompt the user to scan the verification code **3096** provided from the POS system **3020**. The verification code **3096** provides proof of purchase and the link between the SKU and device ID. Using the verification code **3096** to authenticate the purchase, the device management logic **3060** registers the product/device **3000** with the IoT service **2450**, setting the purchase flag **3004** and links the device ID to the SKU **3071** in the device database **3001**.

[0266] If the user cannot locate the verification code, then the user may be prompted to scan the SKU **3071**, rescan the data matrix **3005**, and/or enter additional information. The device manager **3060** may run a troubleshooting handler with this information to attempt to identify the product **3000** and/or determine why the purchase flag **3004** has not been set. For example, due to an error at the factory, the data matrix **3005** may not have been bonded to the device **3000**. If this is determined to be the cause, then the device manager **3060** may link the device ID from the data matrix **3005** to the device (e.g., via the SKU **3071**) in the device database **3001** and register the product/device **3000** with the IoT service **2450**.

[0267] If the problem cannot be resolved via the troubleshooting process, the app of the mobile device **130** may prompt the customer to return to the store or call a number to resolve the issue; such resolutions may involve a tool that the customer service team uses to manually authenticate the purchase. These manual authorizations could be logged for fraud detection purposes.

[0268] FIG. **31A** illustrates a method implemented at a POS system in accordance with some embodiments and FIG. **31B** illustrates a method implemented to setup/activate a device in accordance with some embodiments of the invention.

[0269] At **3101**, the device ID of the product is acquired at the POS. As mentioned, this may be a UUID encoded in an optical code or in an RFID device. At **3102**, a message is transmitted from the POS system to the service indicating that the product with the device ID has been purchased. At **3103**, the service locates the product in a database using the device ID and sets a purchase flag to indicate that the product has been purchased. At **3104**, the POS system generates a verification code (e.g., using a combination of the device ID, SKU, and purchase verification), which it prints on the receipt and/or electronically transmits to the user (e.g., via email, text, etc).

[0270] Turning now to FIG. **31B**, at **3111**, the user executes the app on the mobile device to initiate device setup. At **3112**, the user captures the device ID via the app. For example, the user may be prompted to use the camera to capture the data matrix on the device or the device packaging or may be prompted to establish a wireless connection to the device (e.g., via BTLE or WiFi) to retrieve the device ID.

[0271] At **3113**, the app transmits a message to the service containing the device ID (and potentially other relevant information). At **3114**, the service performs a lookup in the device database using the device ID. If the device ID is linked to the product, determined at **3115**, and the purchase flag has been set, determined at **3116**, then the service registers the device in the user's account at **3117**. If the device ID is not linked to the product and/or the purchase flag has not been set, then at **3118**, the user is prompted by the app to capture or enter the verification code generated by the POS at **3104**. If the user successfully enters the verification code, determined at **3119**, then the service registers the device in the user's account. If the verification code is not entered at **3119**,

the user is instructed to return to the POS or call a number for further assistance.

[0272] Thus, for products that depend on the IoT service **2450** for functionality (e.g., such as an IoT security camera, thermostat, fire detector, or light switch), the customer is buying both the product and the data matrix as a token allow the product to work on at least the baseline tier (or any other tier in the case of a subscription). If the product was stolen, it will not be linked to an account on the IoT service **2450** and will be useless unless the customer properly purchases the product, as indicated by the purchase flag **3004**.

[0273] Some embodiments of the invention validate purchases and activate corresponding products which are not designed to operate with the IoT service **2450** or are otherwise useful without connecting to the IoT service. Examples of such devices include tools (e.g., cordless drills, circular saws, sanders, etc), appliances (e.g., microwaves, blenders, etc), audio/video products (e.g., TVs, Bluetooth speakers, etc), although the underlying principles of the invention are not limited to any particular product types.

[0274] FIG. **32** illustrates one particular embodiment in which each device **3200** is configured with an NFC/RFID tag **3016** which encodes a unique device ID **3202** (e.g., a UUID value) and includes a lock/unlock module **3201**, which can be in a locked state or an unlocked state. In one embodiment, the lock/unlock module **3201** is set to a locked state at the time of manufacture and remains in this state until the product is purchased.

[0275] The NFC/RFID tag **3016** is integrated on the circuit board or integrated circuit of the product **3200** (e.g., the microcontroller unit (MCU)). The lock/unlock module **3201** may be electrically coupled to an internal electrical switch **3250** to enable or disable operation of the product **3200**. For example, the IC switch is set to an unswitched or “off” state when the lock/unlock module **3201** is in the unlocked state and is set to a switched or “on” state when the lock/unlock module **3201** is in the locked state. If the product **3200** includes an MCU, the MCU may read the state of the lock/unlock module **3201** upon initialization to determine whether to enter into an active state.

[0276] In the example illustrated in FIG. **32**, during checkout, the device ID **3202** is captured by an NFC/RFID interface **3015** of the POS system **3020**. Alternatively, or in addition, the device ID **3202** may be encoded in a data matrix and scanned by an optical reader of the POS system **3020** as described above. Once the product **3200** has been purchased, the sale processing logic **3016** transmits a message to the IoT service **2450** and the device management logic **3060** sets the corresponding purchase flag **3004** in the device database **3001** as in the embodiments described above. In addition, in the illustrated embodiment, the NFC/RFID interface **3015** transmits an unlock command **3208** to the NFC/RFID tag **3016** which moves the lock/unlock module **3201** from the locked state to the unlocked state, thereby enabling operation of the product **3200**.

[0277] In some implementations, the product **3200** can also be unlocked after purchase, when the user is no longer at the POS **3020** location. Referring to FIG. **33**, the device ID **3202** may be captured with a user device **135** running an app which connects to the IoT service **2450**. The app may be the IoT app **2801** described above, or may be an app of the retailer from which the product **3200** was purchased (e.g., the Home Depot app, the Best Buy app, etc).

[0278] In operation, the device ID is captured with the camera of the mobile device **135** (e.g., from a data matrix) or using an NFC/RFID interface or other wireless interface of the mobile device **135**. The device ID is transmitted from the app of the mobile device **135** to the IoT service **2450**. The device management logic **3060** performs a lookup in the device database **3001** using the device ID to confirm that the corresponding purchase flag **3004** is set. If purchase flag **3004** is set, the IoT service **2450** transmits an “unlock” message to the user device **135**. The app may then prompt the user to position the mobile device **135** near the device **3200** to allow an NFC/RFID link to be established. Once established, the mobile device **135** transmits an unlock command **3208** to the lock/unlock module **3201** of the NFC/RFID tag **3016**, setting it to the unlocked state as described above, thereby enabling operation of the device **3200**.

[0279] In one embodiment, the lock/unlock module **3201** can be set to the unlocked state once, upon proof of purchase, and is immutable. Thus, once the device is unlocked it cannot be locked again. Alternatively, some embodiments allow the lock/unlock module **3201** to be transitioned between locked and unlocked by an authorized and authenticated user. For example, the user of the mobile device **135** may configure the lock/unlock module **3201** to automatically transition back to the locked state when it has not been used for a specified period of time (e.g., 1 hour, 12 hours, two days, etc). Once in the locked state, the user can unlock the device **3200** via the app on the mobile device **135** as described above. In some implementations, the NFC/RFID tag **3016** may include a clock/calendar and/or timer functionality to allow the user to set a usage schedule for the device **3200**. The device **3200** will then automatically transition between the locked and unlocked states based on the schedule. Even when using a schedule, however, the lock/unlock module **3201** may still require periodic connectivity with a mobile device **135** of the user to be unlocked. Thus, if the device **3200** is stolen, it will eventually become unusable because only the authorized user has the ability to unlock the device **3200**.

[0280] In one embodiment, the user can remove the device **3200** from the user's account on the IoT service **2450** when selling the device **3200**. For example, the app on the mobile device **135** may provide an option to remove the device from the user's account. In response to the user selecting this option, the mobile device **135** transmits a message to the IoT service **2450**, causing the device management logic **3060** to remove the association between the device ID of the device **3200** and the user's account. The purchase flag **3004** remains set in the device database **3001** such that the new user can activate the device **3200** as described above (e.g., via registering the device **3200** with the new user's account and sending an unlock command **3208** to unlock the device **3200**).

[0281] The same sequence of operations may be performed for devices which are associated with a user's account and then returned to the retailer. In one embodiment, the retailer is provided with a sufficient privilege level on the IoT service **2450** to remove a returned device from the initial user's account, making the device **3200** available for use by a subsequent purchaser.

[0282] The embodiments of the invention described above discourage theft, because stolen devices will be inoperative. By way of example, and not limitation, the foreperson at a construction site may control the lock/unlock state of a variety of tools and/or batteries—e.g., setting a daily schedule during which the tools are active and outside of which the tools become locked. If a tool is stolen, it will become inoperative without receiving periodic authorization from the foreman's mobile device **135** running the app. Similarly, if a tool is stolen from a retailer, it will never be made operative because the purchase flag associated with the tool will never be set on the service, and therefore an unlock command will never be authorized to unlock the device.

[0283] Embodiments of the invention may include various steps, which have been described above. The steps may be embodied in machine-executable instructions which may be used to cause a general-purpose or special-purpose processor to perform the steps. Alternatively, these steps may be performed by specific hardware components that contain hardwired logic for performing the steps, or by any combination of programmed computer components and custom hardware components.

[0284] As described herein, instructions may refer to specific configurations of hardware such as application specific integrated circuits (ASICs) configured to perform certain operations or having a predetermined functionality or software instructions stored in memory embodied in a non-transitory computer readable medium. Thus, the techniques shown in the figures can be implemented using code and data stored and executed on one or more electronic devices (e.g., an end station, a network element, etc.). Such electronic devices store and communicate (internally and/or with other electronic devices over a network) code and data using computer machine-readable media, such as non-transitory computer machine-readable storage media (e.g., magnetic disks; optical disks; random access memory; read only memory; flash memory devices; phase-change memory) and transitory computer machine-readable communication media (e.g., electrical,

optical, acoustical or other form of propagated signals—such as carrier waves, infrared signals, digital signals, etc.).

Apparatus and Method for Verification of Product Package Contents and Activation of Corresponding Devices

[0285] Some embodiments of the invention leverage the service-based architecture described herein to prevent theft or unauthorized use of various types of devices, but without the need for a visible data matrix as described in the previous embodiments (although a data matrix may still be used for some implementations).

[0286] In these embodiments, a wireless module in the device is triggered to wake up at checkout. The wireless module may be a Bluetooth (e.g., BLE) module, radio frequency ID (RFID) module, near field communication (NFC) module, WiFi module, or any other module capable of wirelessly communicating the device data as described below. While Bluetooth and NFC are described below with respect to certain embodiments, the underlying principles of the invention are not limited to any particular wireless communication protocol. In one embodiment, the BLE module or NFC module may be activated in response to a radio frequency (RF) burst. In some implementations, the energy from a specific RF burst may be used to power one of these modules long enough to complete the transaction. In other implementations a RF signal may be used to activate an otherwise powered down module. Using energy harvesting, ambient electromagnetic energy (e.g., generated from the POS terminal) may be converted into usable electrical power.

[0287] For a Bluetooth implementation, the product code is scanned as previously described (e.g., via an optical scanner in the case the product code is printed on the product package). The device is awakened by the RF burst at the POS area (though this may have already occurred due to other scanning activity in the area). The device's Bluetooth module is activated and advertises in a Bluetooth extended advertising packet the contents that would have been in the data matrix on the package. As mentioned, this can include, but is not limited to, the device's UUID, the device type, a manufacturing date, etc, and any other relevant information which can be used to uniquely identify the device.

[0288] In some implementations described below, the product code is a UPC code. It should be noted, however, that the embodiments of the invention may be used with any type of product ID code.

[0289] In an embodiment which uses a WiFi module rather than Bluetooth, the WiFi module transmits the device data in Vendor Specific Action Frames in a similar fashion as BLE advertising packets for connectionless message passing.

[0290] The POS system queries the store back-end for a corresponding device manifest keyed off of the product identifier code. In these implementations, the device manifest includes an indication of the sub-units included in the product packaging and is stored in the back-end system when the product and associated product identifier code is added to the store/retailer's POS/sales system. The store back-end may be located at the store location, in a Cloud service, or both, depending on the back-end implementation (e.g., a local back-end instance may be operative and synchronized with the Cloud service). With the product's device manifest, the POS system can identify any sub-units in the product packaging (e.g., a tool bundle kit which includes tools and batteries). The POS system may search for each of the device type(s) listed in the device manifest to ensure that they are in close proximity to the POS system.

[0291] If it locates a match within the manifest, the POS system connects with the device(s) and allows the sale to proceed. If items in the manifest are missing from the POS area, the sale may be held up by either asking the user to reposition the product or flagging the item as possibly being defective. If a mis-match occurs the sale may be blocked because incorrect items may be in the product box.

[0292] When the sale is completed (i.e., after receiving payment from the user) the POS system transmits a request to the store back-end to sign each of the device certificates listed in the manifest

and receives a response with the signed certificate(s). The POS system then sends the signed certificate(s) to each device in the manifest.

[0293] For a NFC/RFID implementation, a similar set of transactions may be performed, but the NFC reader/writer uses a wider transmit (tx)/receive (rx) path. The product UPC (or other form of product ID code) is scanned and the devices are awakened by an RF burst at the POS area. By way of example, and not limitation, the RF burst may be 13.56 MHz for NFC, or at other frequencies for other RFID implementations.

[0294] The POS system queries the store back-end as described above for the UPC device manifest to identify any sub-units in the product package. An NFC/RFID reader at the POS system uses one or more device deconflicting techniques to discover each individual device. For each device, the NFC/RFID reader queries to read out the device-specific data, which is the same data that would have been in the data matrix on the package (e.g., UUID, device type, manufacture date, etc).

[0295] Once the device-specific data has been collected, the POS system operates in the same (or similar) manner as previously described for the Bluetooth or WiFi implementations—i.e., comparing the manifest information with the devices it was able to locate. If it locates a match within the manifest, the POS system connects with the device(s) and allows the sale to proceed. If items in the manifest are missing from the POS area, the sale may be held up by either asking the user to reposition the product or flagging the item as possibly being defective. If a mis-match occurs the sale may be blocked because incorrect items may be in the product box.

[0296] When the sale is complete (payment received) the POS system transmits a request to the store back-end to sign each of the device certificates listed in the manifest. Upon receiving the signed certificates, the POS system wakes up the device(s) with the NFC or RFID field and connects to each device in the manifest (e.g., one-by-one) to write the signed certificate to that device.

[0297] The POS system may also provide instructions to the cashier/customer to reposition the product package with respect to the POS system's reader/writer depending upon the range.

[0298] For online or catalog sales, the “POS system” is a fulfillment station where the product package is boxed and prepared for shipment. In these implementations, the fulfillment station is configured to operate in substantially the same manner as the POS system described herein. For example, in response to a product ID scanner at the fulfillment station, such as a UPC scanner if the product ID is a UPC, an RF burst can be triggered to activate the devices within the product package, which then communicate device identification information to the fulfillment station (e.g., via WiFi, Bluetooth, RFID, NFC, etc). The fulfillment station retrieves the UPC manifest (e.g., from a back-end database) and compares the devices detected with the UPC manifest. Thus, if any devices are missing from the product package, this problem can be identified at the fulfillment station, prior to shipping the product package to the user.

[0299] In some embodiments, if a manufacturer is shipping a product package to a retailer that does not have support for the techniques described herein (e.g., does not support a wireless connection to receive the device information from packaged devices), the manufacturer can unlock the devices at the manufacturer's factory during pack out. In these cases, a product distribution station at the factory can perform all or a subset of the functions described above with respect to the POS system and fulfillment station to confirm the devices included in the product package. Similarly these same functions can be carried out by an authorized distributor at a product distribution station in their distribution warehouse.

[0300] Thus, embodiments of the invention may be implemented within any distribution channel from the manufacturer to the retailer, from the retailer to the user, or directly from the manufacturer to the user. Any intermediate station within one of these distribution channels may be configured in accordance with the embodiments of the invention described herein with respect to the POS system.

[0301] Using these embodiments, there is no need for a data matrix for each protected sub-device.

The manifest, identified via the UPC code, has device types attached to it. Thus, a tool such as a drill can be manufactured in exactly the same way for a tool only sale as for a tool+battery package. This also ensures that the correct tool and corresponding batteries are in a kit when sold AND when returned. For example, when returning the product, the POS system at the return desk can query the package to ensure that all of the devices listed in the UPC manifest are present in the package.

[0302] FIG. **34** illustrates a Bluetooth implementation in accordance with some embodiments of the invention. In some embodiments, a low energy (LE) implementation of Bluetooth (BT) is used, such as the LE implementations of Bluetooth 5.2, 5.3, or 5.4. Note, however, that the underlying principles of the invention are not limited to any particular Bluetooth implementation.

[0303] As mentioned, the product UPC code **3471** of the product package **3400** is scanned with a UPC reader **3417** on the POS system **3420** as previously described. An RF trigger module **3405A-B** awakens one or more devices (e.g., devices **3410A-B** in the illustrated example) in the product packaging **3400** in response to an RF burst at the POS area. In some embodiments, an RF burst generator **3418** in the POS system is configured to generate the RF burst when the UPC code **3471** is scanned. Alternatively, the RF burst generator **3418** may periodically generate RF bursts (e.g., every few seconds) to activate any devices which are nearby.

[0304] Once activated, each device's Bluetooth module **3411A-B** is configured to transmit a Bluetooth extended advertising packet **3441A-B** containing the data that would have been in the data matrix on the package (as described with respect to the prior embodiments). As mentioned, this can include, but is not limited to, the UUID of the device **3410A-B**, the device type, a manufacturing date, hardware and/or software version information, a MAC address, etc, and any other relevant information which can be used to uniquely identify each device **3410A-B**.

[0305] In some embodiments, manifest/sale processing logic **3416** uses the UPC data **3471** to generate a query for the UPC device manifest to the store's back-end system **3490**. The UPC device manifest indicates the set of devices which are expected to be included in the product packaging **3400**. The back-end system **3490** uses the UPC data provided to retrieve the UPC device manifest **3480** from a back-end database **3483** and transmits the manifest to the manifest/sale processing logic **3416**.

[0306] In one embodiment, the manifest/sale processing logic **3416** uses the UPC device manifest to identify any sub-units in the product packaging **3400** (e.g., such as a tool bundle kit which includes both tools and batteries) and may then search in detected advertising packets **3441A-B** for the devices **3410A-B** that are expected to be in the product package **3400**. If it is able to match the detected devices **3410A-B** with the corresponding UPC device manifest, the manifest/sale processing logic **3416** connects with the device(s) **3410A-B** and allows the sale to proceed.

[0307] In one embodiment, when the sale is completed (i.e., after receiving payment from the user) the manifest/sale processing logic **3016** transmits a request to the store back-end **3490** to sign the device certificates for the devices listed in the manifest **3480**. Signature generation logic **3488** in the back-end system generates the signatures and transmits the signed certificates **3489A-B** to the manifest/sale processing logic **3416**, which transmits the signed certificates to each device **3410A-B**. Although the signed certificates **3489A-B** are illustrated over a separate communication path for clarity, the signed certificates **3489A-B** may be transmitted to the devices **3410A-B** via the BT interface **3415**.

[0308] The signed certificates may be stored on the devices **3410A-B** in a non-volatile storage and/or used to unlock the devices **3410A-B**, using any of the techniques described above (e.g., via a lock/unlock module **3201** and switch **3250**). In addition, the device database **3001** on the IoT service **2450** may be updated as previously described (e.g., setting a purchase flag **3004** in the device database **3001** for the corresponding devices).

[0309] FIG. **35** illustrates a NFC/RFID implementation in accordance with some embodiments of the invention. These embodiments operate in a similar manner as the Bluetooth embodiments in

FIG. 34, with one exception being that communication is provided using NFC or other RFID standard. While the discussion below sometimes refers only to NFC, the underlying principles of the invention may be implemented using any RFID protocol or standard.

[0310] As mentioned, the product UPC code **3471** of the product package **3500** is scanned with a UPC reader **3417** on the POS system **3420** as previously described. RF trigger modules **3505A-B** awaken one or more devices (e.g., devices **3510A-B** in the illustrated example) in the packaging in response to an RF burst at the POS area. In some embodiments, an RF burst generator **3418** is configured to generate the RF burst when the UPC code **3471** is scanned. Alternatively, the RF burst generator **3418** may periodically generate RF bursts (e.g., every few seconds).

[0311] Once activated, each device's NFC module **3511A-B** is configured to transmit one or more packets with the data that would have been in the data matrix on the package. An NFC/RFID interface **3515** with an NFC/RFID reader and transmitter at the POS system **3420** uses one or more device deconflicting techniques to discover the transmission from the NFC modules **3511A-B** of each individual device **3510A-B**. As mentioned, the data transmitted can include, but is not limited to, the UUID of the device **3510A-B**, the device type, a manufacturing date, or any other relevant information which can be used to uniquely identify each device **3510A-B**.

[0312] The manifest/sale processing logic **3416** uses the UPC data **3471** to generate a query for the UPC device manifest to the store's back-end system **3490**. The UPC device manifest indicates the set of devices which are expected to be included in the product packaging **3400**. The back-end system **3490** retrieves the UPC device manifest **3480** from a database **3483** based on the UPC data provided and transmits it to the manifest/sale processing logic **3416**.

[0313] In one embodiment, the manifest/sale processing logic **3416** uses the UPC device manifest to identify any sub-units in the product packaging **3400** (e.g., such as a tool bundle kit which includes both tools and batteries). The manifest/sale processing logic **3416** may then search in the detected NFC transmissions for the devices **3510A-B** that are expected to be in the product package **3500**. If it is able to match the detected devices **3510A-B** with the corresponding UPC device manifest, the manifest/sale processing logic **3416** allows the sale to proceed.

[0314] In one embodiment, when the sale is completed (i.e., after receiving payment from the user) the manifest/sale processing logic **3416** transmits a request to the store back-end **3490** to sign each of the device certificates listed in the manifests **3480**. Signature generation logic **3488** generates the signatures and transmits the signed certificates **3489A-B**, which the manifest/sale processing logic **3416** may then transmit to each device **3510A-B** in the manifest. Although illustrated over a separate communication path for clarity, the signed certificates **3489A-B** may be transmitted to the devices **3510A-B** via the NFC interface **3515**.

[0315] The signed certificates may be stored on the devices **3510A-B** in a non-volatile storage and/or used to unlock the devices **3510A-B**, using any of the techniques described above (e.g., via a lock/unlock module **3201** and switch **3250**). In addition, the device database **3001** on the IoT service **2450** may be updated as previously described (e.g., setting a purchase flag **3004** in the device database **3001** for the corresponding devices).

[0316] FIG. 36 illustrates a method in accordance with embodiments of the invention. The method may be implemented within the context of the various architectures described herein, but is not limited to any particular architecture or any particular set of communication channels.

[0317] At **3601**, the UPC code of the product package is scanned with a UPC reader on the POS system. At **3602**, the devices in the product package are awakened (e.g., via RF trigger modules) and begin wirelessly transmitting device data. In a BT implementation, BT extended advertising packets may be used while in an NFC/RFID implementation, corresponding NFC/RFID channels are used.

[0318] At **3603**, the POS system retrieves the UPC device manifest from the back-end of the POS system (e.g., from a local or remote server). At **3604**, the POS system listens over BT or NFC/RFID channels (or both) to detect transmissions from the devices or device types listed in the

manifest. If all devices in the manifest are detected at **3605**, then the purchase is permitted to proceed at **3606**. At **3607**, signed certificates are generated (e.g., by the back-end system) and send to the respective devices. The IoT database may also be updated as previously described to indicate that the devices have been purchased.

[0319] If all devices in the manifest are not detected, then additional instructions may be provided to the user at the POS in an attempt to acquire the information. For example, the instructions may explain how to position the product package with respect to the POS system. Alternatively, or additionally, secondary operations may be performed, such as generating commands to increase the transmission power of the POS interfaces and/or device interfaces. If the devices cannot be detected, the POS operator may be instructed to open the product package, confirm its contents, and manually enter the device information into the POS system.

[0320] Using these embodiments, there is no need to bind specific tools/batteries at the time of manufacture, thereby reducing the burden on manufacturers when they offer special one-time-buys for a kit configuration to manage excess inventory.

[0321] These techniques may also be used for inventory in the store or warehouse. Directional antennas can be used to remotely trigger any devices and then listen for their response signals with their device types. This allows big-box stores and warehouses to locate missing high-value stock.

[0322] The electronic devices described herein may include a set of one or more processors coupled to one or more other components, such as one or more storage devices (non-transitory machine-readable storage media), user input/output devices (e.g., a keyboard, a touchscreen, and/or a display), and network connections. The coupling of the set of processors and other components is typically through one or more busses and bridges (also termed as bus controllers). Additionally, one or more parts of an embodiment of the invention may be implemented using different combinations of software, firmware, and/or hardware.

[0323] Throughout this detailed description, for the purposes of explanation, numerous specific details were set forth in order to provide a thorough understanding of the present invention. It will be apparent, however, to one skilled in the art that the invention may be practiced without some of these specific details. In certain instances, well known structures and functions were not described in elaborate detail in order to avoid obscuring the subject matter of the present invention.

Accordingly, the scope and spirit of the invention should be judged in terms of the claims which follow.

Claims

1. A method comprising: scanning an optical code on a product package at a point-of-sale (POS) system or product distribution terminal and generating a digital code based on the optical code; generating a radio-frequency (RF) burst to activate devices in the product package, each of the devices to responsively transmit identification information associated with the respective device; identifying a device manifest using the digital code, the device manifest indicating a set of devices intended to be included in the product package; detecting the identification information transmitted by one or more devices included in the product package; comparing the identification information with the set of devices indicated by the device manifest; allowing a purchase of the product package to proceed if the identification information matches the set of devices; and if the identification information does not match the set of devices, then performing one or more secondary operations and/or providing instructions at the POS system or product distribution terminal to attempt to verify that the devices in the product package match the set of devices indicated by the device manifest.

2. The method of claim 1, further comprising: following the one or more secondary operations and/or provision of the instructions, subsequently allowing the purchase of the product package or distribution of the product package to proceed upon verification that the devices in the product

package match the set of devices indicated by the device manifest.

3. The method of claim 1, wherein responsive to the purchase of the product package: transmitting a first message from the POS system or product distribution terminal, the first message including a device identifier (ID) corresponding to the identification information, the device ID to uniquely identify a device included in the product package; identifying an entry in a device database of an internet of things (IoT) service based on the device ID, the entry including a field to indicate whether the device has been purchased; updating the field responsive to a message received from the POS system that the device has been purchased; authorizing unlocking of the device; establishing a short-range wireless connection between a mobile device of a user or the POS system or product distribution terminal and the device; and transmitting an unlock command from the mobile device or the POS system over the short range wireless connection, wherein a lock module of the device is to transition from a locked state to an unlocked state responsive to receipt of the unlock command.

4. The method of claim 1 wherein the identification information is transmitted by the devices over a Near Field Communication (NFC), radio frequency identification (RFID), WiFi, or Bluetooth connection.

5. The method of claim 4 wherein one or more of the devices include an RF trigger module to cause a corresponding wireless interface to activate and transmit at least a portion of the identification information.

6. The method of claim 1 wherein if the purchase of the product package is allowed to proceed, then: generating at least one signature over at least one device certificate associated with at least one device included in the product package to generate at least one signed certificate; transmitting the at least one signed certificate to at least one corresponding device, the corresponding device to store the signed certificate and/or to use to signed certificate to unlock one or more features of the corresponding device.

7. The method of claim 1 wherein detecting the identification information transmitted by the one or more devices comprises reading the identification information from a Bluetooth extended advertising packet transmitted from the one or more devices.

8. The method of claim 1 wherein detecting the identification information transmitted by the one or more devices comprises reading the identification information from a Near Field Communication (NFC) or Radio Frequency ID (RFID) packet transmitted by the one or more devices.

9. A machine-readable medium having program code stored thereon which, when executed by a machine, causes the machine to perform operations, comprising: scanning an optical code on a product package at a point-of-sale (POS) system or product distribution terminal and generating a digital code based on the optical code; generating a radio-frequency (RF) burst to activate devices in the product package, each of the devices to responsively transmit identification information associated with the respective device; identifying a device manifest using the digital code, the device manifest indicating a set of devices intended to be included in the product package; detecting the identification information transmitted by one or more devices included in the product package; comparing the identification information with the set of devices indicated by the device manifest; and allowing a purchase of the product package to proceed if the identification information matches the set of devices; wherein if the identification information does not match the performing one or more secondary operations and/or providing instructions at the POS system or product distribution terminal to attempt to verify that the devices in the product package match the set of devices indicated by the device manifest.

10. The machine-readable medium of claim 9, further comprising program code to cause the operation of: following the one or more secondary operations and/or provision of the instructions, subsequently allowing the purchase of the product package or distribution of the product package to proceed upon verification that the devices in the product package match the set of devices indicated by the device manifest.

11. The machine-readable medium of claim 9, wherein responsive to the purchase of the product package: transmitting a first message from the POS system or product distribution terminal, the first message including a device identifier (ID) corresponding to the identification information, the device ID to uniquely identify a device included in the product package; identifying an entry in a device database of an internet of things (IoT) service based on the device ID, the entry including a field to indicate whether the device has been purchased; updating the field responsive to a message received from the POS system that the device has been purchased; authorizing unlocking of the device; establishing a short-range wireless connection between a mobile device of a user or the POS system or product distribution terminal and the device; and transmitting an unlock command from the mobile device or the POS system over the short range wireless connection, wherein a lock module of the device is to transition from a locked state to an unlocked state responsive to receipt of the unlock command.

12. The machine-readable medium of claim 9 wherein the identification information is transmitted by the devices over a Near Field Communication (NFC), radio frequency identification (RFID), WiFi, or Bluetooth connection.

13. The machine-readable medium of claim 12 wherein one or more of the devices include an RF trigger module to cause a corresponding wireless interface to activate and transmit at least a portion of the identification information.

14. The machine-readable medium of claim 9 wherein if the purchase of the product package is allowed to proceed, then: generating at least one signature over at least one device certificate associated with at least one device included in the product package to generate at least one signed certificate; transmitting the at least one signed certificate to at least one corresponding device, the corresponding device to store the signed certificate and/or to use to signed certificate to unlock one or more features of the corresponding device.

15. The machine-readable medium of claim 9 wherein detecting the identification information transmitted by the one or more devices comprises reading the identification information from a Bluetooth extended advertising packet transmitted from the one or more devices.

16. The machine-readable medium of claim 9 wherein detecting the identification information transmitted by the one or more devices comprises reading the identification information from a Near Field Communication (NFC) or Radio Frequency ID (RFID) packet transmitted by the one or more devices.

17. A system, comprising: an optical scanner to scan an optical code on a product package and generate a corresponding digital code; a database to store a device manifest indicating a set of devices intended to be included in the product package, the device manifest to be accessed using the digital code; a radio frequency (RF) burst module to generate a radio-frequency (RF) burst to activate devices in the product package, one or more of the devices to responsively transmit identification information associated with the respective device; a wireless interface to detect the identification information transmitted by the one or more devices; and verification logic to compare the identification information with the set of devices indicated by the device manifest and to allow a purchase of the product package to proceed if the identification information matches the set of devices; wherein one or more secondary operations are to be performed and/or instructions are to be provided to attempt to verify that the devices in the product package match the set of devices indicated by the device manifest.

18. The system of claim 17, wherein following the one or more secondary operations and/or provision of the instructions, a corresponding POS system is to subsequently allow the purchase of the product package to proceed or a corresponding product distribution terminal is to allow distribution of the product package upon verification that the devices in the product package match the set of devices indicated by the device manifest.

19. The system of claim 17, wherein responsive to the purchase of the product package, the POS system is to transmit a first message including a device identifier (ID) corresponding to the

identification information to an Internet of Things (IoT) service, the device ID to uniquely identify a device included in the product package; the IoT service to identify an entry in a device database based on the device ID, the entry including a field to indicate whether the device has been purchased, the IoT service to update the field responsive to a message received from the POS system that the device has been purchased; responsive to an authorization to unlock the device, the POS system or a mobile user device to establish a short-range wireless connection with the device and to transmit an unlock command, wherein a lock module of the device is to transition from a locked state to an unlocked state responsive to receipt of the unlock command.

20. The system of claim 1 wherein the identification information is transmitted by the devices over a Near Field Communication (NFC), radio frequency identification (RFID), WiFi, or Bluetooth connection.

21. The system of claim 20 wherein one or more of the devices include an RF trigger module to cause a corresponding wireless interface to activate and transmit at least a portion of the identification information.

22. The system of claim 17 wherein if the purchase of the product package is allowed to proceed, then the POS system or product distribution terminal is to cause at least one signature to be generated over at least one device certificate associated with at least one device included in the product package to generate at least one signed certificate and to transmit the at least one signed certificate to at least one corresponding device, the corresponding device to store the signed certificate and/or to use the signed certificate to unlock one or more features of the corresponding device.

23. The system of claim 17 wherein the POS system or product distribution terminal is to detect the identification information transmitted by the one or more devices by reading the identification information from a Bluetooth extended advertising packet transmitted from the one or more devices.

24. The system of claim 17 wherein the POS system or product distribution terminal is to detect the identification information transmitted by the one or more devices comprises reading the identification information from a Near Field Communication (NFC) or Radio Frequency ID (RFID) packet transmitted by the one or more devices.
